

Klaus Kinski

Kern

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Fair is foul and foul is fair:
Hover through the fog and filthy air.

Macbeth, Act I Scene I

This is an exorcism. A hit on my demons. *J'accuse* (fuck my French) of the devil-system. God saw in his wisdom to make me an atheist. The Catholic part's incurable.

Always tryna work out the big picture in my head. Big web. Big mess. Like the fuckin Syrian Civil War. So many factions no one even knows whose side is whose. You know.

Got PTS and prolly fitty concussions. My friends joke you ask Kern somethin, an hour later you'll get an answer. And I'm like, Well it's funny you say that cuz time is relative...

Tried to talk some sense into the Kid the other day. You can tell a trustafarian cuz he says shit like, ``Don't be sorry, be better." Wanna strangle somethin like that. You know? Guy's never been in a jail.

First thing to understand about Rikers is the doors don't work. I mean the cell doors do not lock. Why? There are a few reasons. One: Inmates make what they call 'Keys.' These consist of a thin piece of bedsheet torn into a strip. The locking mechanism is essentially a heavy duty version of a hook & an eye. So perps'll tie the sheet strip around the hook, the latch. You can't see it from the outside. When they want out they simply pull up on it and it unlocks. Some use soap whittled down and stuffed into the eye mechanism. These are easier to pull open from the outside. Then there are sliding doors that when you play with them enough, just rocking back and forth, they swing open because the track they are on is just worn the fuck out. It can be creepy when

you are on overnight tour in the dark, locked in with people who may be facing life and have nothing to lose just decide they want out.

The Bureau of Corrections, civilians, I've only interacted with them a few times, they work with the Mayor, and they can at any time walk into a jail and show their ID and you have to let them in, few people have that privilege. I'm walking one time and it's early morning, 5, 6, and one of them shows up and wants to walk down the tier with me, and suddenly a guy sticks his head out, the guy from the Bureau's fuckin terrified, and the prisoner closes the door like My bad! And I say, Yeah a lotta the doors don't work and he says We know that. Everybody knows man. It's like the story Zizek used to tell, Stalin's drinking, everyone's drinking round the table, and someone stands up and says, You're a liar you're a murderer you're this and that, you know. And another guy stands up and responds, How dare you say that to the General Secretary, you can't say that here. And you know, Zizek's point is, That second guy? Who calls the first guy out? He'll be first to the gulag, because you're supposed to be able to criticize, this ain't the public narrative. You're all playing all this false, this false consciousness, you're always speaking to the Big Other. That's what it's like in jail, that's Rikers.

I'm talking to this rookie who is telling me about getting sucker punched while writing in his log book. His glasses go flying, break. His head hits the concrete. You know what he tells me? He tells me the first thought went through his head was "Oh shit I

hope there's no cell doors open." Not out of fear of the inmates. Out of fear of the Department. I wanted to cry hearing that. The doors belong in a friggin museum. I mean they're museum pieces. And when they're broke, maintenance can't fix em because they don't make the replacement parts, I mean, they're holding together with spit and bubble gum. Think Cuba, the guys still tryna keep '57 Chevies running.

I guess that's part of the reason I'm telling you all this shit. For that rookie, and all the others like him. The other reason is this guy, my guru, he told me, Kern, you gotta get it down on paper, you gotta get it out of you. He wrote a book called *White N****r*. Guy was a combat medic in Vietnam, afterward drinkin himself to death in the 70s and 80s, went over to Ireland and was involved over there, puttin his skills to work, got involved with you know. He's very justice-oriented. He was a medic, you know? It's not like he was blowing people to pieces.

Then he went to Somalia, he's got dual citizenship with Ireland, I do too. First generation through my mother. My father's family goes way back in this country, centuries even, my great-grandfather helped build the Brooklyn Bridge or something, so I heard. Somewhere in one of those cemeteries maybe St Patrick's Church, we got relatives. How many people you know was buried in Manhattan? Anyway, guy ends up in Baghdad in advance of the invasion, you know, and he's filming Shock & Awe from the rooftops, that's how crazy this guy is. A Hell's Kitchen

native who I'm forever in debt to for helping me keep the maniac inside my skull tethered with love and taught me to try to embrace the monster without it embracing me by getting some garbage out instead of stuffing it.

Back and knees fucked up from dealing with inmates. Anam Rashid, shorter than me but built like a fireplug. Knifed a poor Chinese girl to death, followed her into her building.

I got a belt around him, hands cuffed to his belt but you can't fuckin ankle-brace him case he slips, some liability crap. Gotta wait til he's on the bus. So he stops and he won't go, he's blockin the gate so Captain comes along, You gotta move this fuckin guy, I'm like, Yo Cap you're here now you're the boss, what do you want me to do? He says, Take 'im down. Tries to spray the guy, sprays my partner instead, I mean misses Rashid entirely, my partner is out, I'm rollin around with him on the ground and he's got that retard strength, you know? And the spray's affecting me too, and my back's already jacked up.

But that's not what took me outta commission. I'm out cause they changed the ganghouse policy.

Used to be they'd split em up, you know. Five Crips, five Bloods, five Latin Kings, five Trinitarios, five neutrals. Keep the balance of power. Nowadays they let em all live together, keep all their cats with them. Less in-fighting now so the numbers look good for the supes, but what the supes don't think of is, now they're focused all that energy and aggression and hostility on you. Focused on fucking you up. Or

on fucking up some other houses.

These guys they know your fuckin body clock better than you do. They're there 18 hours, they know when you're gonna get a coffee, fill your water bottle, piss, you know.

Now, a lot of people confuse jails and prisons. Rikers is a jail, it's where you go while you're waiting for trial. Average stay is six months or under. People bail out, plead out. It's a game, waiting for trial. Some people try to stretch it out, delay delay delay. Some people are trying to stay in the jail system cuz it's all they know. Rikers, as far as jails go, is much better than prison. Once you go to prison, the state owns you. You're not a name you're a number that's it, and you'll die up there. But at Rikers, you're—technically—innocent til proven guilty, which means you've got more rights.

Rikers is also a direct supervision environment. That means it's you and your body in the same room as the inmates. You're not sitting in another room watching cameras, sitting in a bubble behind glass. There are cameras, to be sure, but they're there for legal, they're there for the city, they're there to protect the inmates.

Guys are coming in and out of houses, there's a rotating cast, new Crips coming in and out. Someone's always running the house. Shotcallers. That's the head inmate, runs the house. I mean, in theory the prison runs the house but you know. The shotcallers'd keep their guys in check sometimes, tell their guys, Cut it out, cuz if this turns up they gonna

tear this house apart, and you know what they got, drugs n shit. They don't want the tactical search team in there. So sometimes you can hold guys off when they're bein difficult, saner minds prevail, you know? In everybody's interest to keep the heat off.

So when you're new to a house, you've gotta figure out who's the leader. You always ask so you know who to talk to, if you're gonna be there for a week. Just to say, I'm not gonna fuck with you, I certainly didn't put you here, but I'm gonna do my job for the week I'm here, and tough if you don't like it. They'll test you too, send a minion, see how you react. They'll throw your logbook on the floor, move a chair around, see how you play it. If they sense someone's real scared, they'll shark-attack em, get all around em and scream in their face. Intimidation games. Rookies'll quit on the spot sometimes, that happens.

Point being that nowadays, you're in an MS13 house, or a Blood house, and one of em swings at you, and you swing back? Now you swung on the whole group. Whole club's involved. Story is the Hells Angels started it. You're not swingin on the person you're swingin on the patch and you're looking to catch a beat down. Goddamn MS13 almost killed me, ripped my head open, I lose a tooth, surgery for months. Still have a hit on me those guys. Barbarians.

A lot's changed since I started. Island's three times bigger than it used to be. Landfilled with rocks 'n the crushed bones of the fuckin Lenape. Dug and dumped for the subway tunnels right through a burial

ground.

Now they wanna extend the La Guardia runways, land their fuckin Airbus Flying Palaces, you know; these are the people who run the world. They wanna privatize the jails. I was working the gate, thirty people come through from the Manhattan Institute lookin like they just came outta Yale, young n suits n shit, they wanna see a warden. Now the Manhattan Institute's *raison d'être* is to privatize shit, you know what I mean? So everyone in power, they want the jail to fail. They could make the place safer but they don't wanna, they just paint the walls, so at quarterly meetings they can say they're spendin all this money but nothin's happenin, so alright folks, looks like it's cheaper just to tear her down, build a new one, and the tax payers' on the hook.

And the Feds put the cams in. Before, the COs didn't do shit, they'd hang in the bubble and drink all day, and if shit hit the fan, they'd go way over the top, send guys to the hospital with fuckin broken orbital bones. I remember guys would tell me they'd take their uniforms off. Shirt with the shield on it, that shit came off, you wore your t-shirt til breakfast came.

My career straddles before and after the cameras. They'd installed some of the camera boxes but they didn't have cameras in them yet. I'd look into who got that camera contract because there are more cameras in Rikers than Times Square. I think I told you already about, I was holding this guy's face, holding his head down by the back of the neck, cuz

they were punching him in the back of the head, and I'm thinking, this is my post, if he comes in on the camera and there's nothing wrong with him, and then he leaves looking like he just did a couple rounds with Mike Tyson, I'm going down. I think this guy had spit on a female officer. Once they got him in that room, it didn't have a camera because it was for piss-testing and stuff, it was where they'd take ya to catch a beating. So they were whaling on him on the sides, and I'm like, if that's what it's gotta be that's what it's gotta be, cuz you can't see damage there. But don't go breakin heads. It had such a violent... I mean people died in that place.

When I started out there was crazy shit everywhere, I mean nothing can prepare you, and I'd ask other COs you know, veterans, Yo how do you deal with this shit? They'd say, you gotta make this job work for you. As you do it you start to understand, you gotta develop your own style. Nothing can prepare you. The best officers, their style works maybe 70% of the time. The average ones, 40% of the time. The ones it works 10% of the time either move up the ranks and become a captain, or else they leave, cuz they can't cut it on the floor.

Captains would handle alerts totally differently man to man. A Code B alert means there's some shit going down, someone has a weapon or has made a threat. If a Code B goes off all the guys in the lunch room, they call it the keepers kitchen. That's where officers would be hanging out, COs used to be called keepers back in the day. But all the guys,

you'd look around the room put together a team of guys who can throw, because half of em can't, they're 90lbs, so you look around and say, alright, who's our muscle, and then you head to the house to throw down. Sometimes the issue's easily rectifiable, you know, guys were supposed to get bananas with their lunch and they didn't, and they saw other guys down the hall eating bananas. Sometimes it's just guys looking for trouble over nothin. And captains have very different styles how they respond. Sometimes the captain'll stand there and argue with guys. Try to talk em down. Sometimes the captain's of the belief that might makes right. And he figures—not totally wrongly either—that if the COs working your house called in a problem? If they can't talk you down, the guys who know you best? Then what the fuck am I gonna say to change your mind? So they'd just go right in swinging. Sometimes it was a mess and you don't have time to talk, I mean you're on your lunch break you're already missing your lunch break and you're suited up, gas mask on, baton in your hand, and you get the order to just gas up the whole house, like, let's end this. It was war. Everyone's gettin it. I remember this guy loved to spray motherfuckers, he carried three OCs, bear spray and then two backups in his belt, he'd just hose em down. Sometimes the inmates see your team show up in suits, they say naw, today's not the today, and they settle down.

They can teach you all the rules and regs in Academy but when you're dealing with a house and it's 30 or 50 guys, 30 or 50 hurtin motherfuckers

you know what I mean? Their life is about getting one over. Every interaction you have, the way they see it, every interaction someone's getting played. Everyone is either a predator or prey in this situation. And it could be something, it could be the smallest thing, on the micro level, a couple packets of sugar. These fuckers will fight over a fuckin cups worth of instant coffee. Somethin to do cuz you're climbin the walls, something to just keep your mind occupied fighting over all this shit.

Not to mention, the Academy leaves half the important shit out, it's all theory, zero zilch practice. The perps are the ones help orient you, they've been around, they know the drill, if they're in the mood, they'll tell you. It's a collaboration almost, sometimes, keeping out of trouble, keeping everyone, inmates, officers, low profile. No one wants a raid, no one wants a lockdown.

My personal style? Is respect. We're all stuck in here together. I'll treat you like an adult til you prove me different. We've all got our roles in the system. You give me a hard day I'll give you a hard day, but I'm not here to fuck with you. Guys'll put on appearances for captains they respect, they'll know how to act, keep the doors closed when captain walks by.

One of the reasons I was able to retire early. I was never what they call a Robo Cop, this big muscular dude who says, Make no mistake I'm in charge here. Those guys can get jumped just so they an inmate can get one, over win points for taking him out, put a target on his back. But like I said, I'm more a dude to

give respect. In a max house, fuckin murderer's row, guys who're never gonna see the streets again, or guys who just got a DUI, I treat em all the same. You used to sit in a plastic chair with your logbook, now we got desks, kinda like in the old movies when they go into a hotel, big hardbound thing, ledger lines, and I always just did my job. And on that job if you're doing your job you're already a step above. You're doing too much. Most guys are fuckin goin to sleep. Yeah you heard that right. Guys sleep in the pocket, hang out on their phones, gossip. That's how you get through 22 years without any problems. The more you work the more you're gonna get worked. You know what I mean? That's the idealism. I was tryna make a difference, my credo was, I'm responsible for the effort not the outcome. That's how I lived my life. But then I realized, these guys, the Department, they can take your job at any moment. They'd love to, it'd make their day.

There's all this paperwork but it's just a setup. You're comin in at midnight, 2300, you check the doors you check the fire extinguisher make sure everything's secure count bodies make sure everyone's alive. One of the things you gotta fill out is what called a Random Search Report, every single tour, ten dudes you've gotta frisk them. Basically, ten dudes at random like, Yo my man do me a favor. Sometimes if I'm on a day tour, I mean first you don't wanna put your hands on them. But you're playin for the camera, you know, lemme pat you down, then you'd write down their booking number

and the search finding, no contraband at this time. But you come in at midnight they want a report by 1AM, how are you gonna frisk em? You can't. You go into the bubble where the camera can't see you, you pull ten guys' cards, and you write a report saying no contraband. My Captain, he told me to do this. Straight up. It's crazy.

Everybody knows. I'm in a max house, new to the job, working overtime. Most of the stories are early in the job, because you get so numb to it, it doesn't register anymore. I go to sit down in my plastic chair they say, Yo CO get up, that's our chair. I was like, They didn't cover this in the Academy. Cuz usually when people get too close to you, you gotta stand up. But they want my chair. So I'm sitting there like, Naw I ain't gettin up. They're like, No fuck you CO you gotta get off this fuckin chair. Call the captain tell him get this fuckin cracker outta here tell em he's racist you know. And I'm thinking I'm gonna get picked up like in a Jewish wedding and carried around. How the fuck is this gonna look on a camera? I say that and they start crackin up you know what I mean? And they're like, alright, I see where this guy's comin from, he's gonna sit and write in his fuckin book, he's cool. That's what I mean by, you gotta make it work for you. That style doesn't work for everyone. Everyone's got their own dynamic. This one black woman I see her slapping some guy's ass like, Get in there nigga what you doin. Well that wouldn't work for you know, me a white guy or whatever. You gotta find your personal style.

It's all about the cameras. Half the job is acting right for the cameras. Inmates, COs. The Feds technically own the cameras. There is a division that monitors them, as can the warden, tour commanders. I've gotten calls to report to the bubble. That's an A-station on post. Only land line. And it's the people monitoring the camera. Can't remember the division name. Say, Hey your pantry worker is serving up trays without a hairnet on. They're not wearing an apron. But I've never even heard of one of them guys giving an officer a heads up that something dangerous is incoming.

Lemme tell you a little story about performing for the camera. 2014 was when the Feds ordered cameras to be installed in all jails. It was a slow job getting them installed. We had to adapt along with the changes. For instance. The incident with MS13. When I came back from the hospital. This is a few years later, 2017. Every officer I saw came up hugged me and whispered "You already know." See, there were cameras in the housing area I was assaulted in. By that time, in pretty much every cell area and most of the dorms, there were cameras. But not in the main clinic or the mental health clinic and some parts of intake, due to HIPAA laws. During roll call, the good managers would be like, "Look, you know you're on camera. Those cameras are not there to protect you," which, damn right. No, "They are there to protect the inmates. So, be aware and make that movie. Step back put your hand up and spray em." The reason for this? Well, protocol dictates that any inmate exposed

to chemical agent must be examined in the medical clinic in timely fashion. See where I'm going with this? No cameras in there. That's where we got our payback. In my case, I was told in no uncertain terms that after I EMS'd out and the guys who jumped me were in a holding cell in the clinic? There was a line fifty deep of officers who took turns enlightening those perps what the consequences were. So the perps ended up getting EMS'd out too. But much later, and not walking under their own power.

It's premodern, pre-law. *Blood Meridian* shit, frontier justice. Wild West system built on honor and respect, violence and fear. The public front is that it's oh so civilized, just another enlightened bureaucracy, but we know the truth. Sink or swim. Predator or prey. Rikers is a dinosaur stuck in a tarpit. A crossroads of the way things are and the way things were. But society? Doesn't wanna know. It can't handle the truth.

I gotta take a break, gimme a sec. New medication in the morning's giving me hiccups. Old bartender's trick. You take a pint glass of water, cover it with a paper towel, hold it as tight over the top as possible, and drink the whole thing breathing through your nose. I think there's a mental trick to it. I've done it with slow breathing too, it goes away. It's a spasm, right? I think it's about concentration, breathing through your nose, relaxing, I haven't figured it out.

Okay. Where was I. Well, I guess we'll kick it back a little, how I got into the DOC in the first place. Shit, before Corrections, I was hustlin, man.

It'd be quicker to tell you what I haven't done. My first work was through the bars. I come from a part of Brooklyn known as Bay Ridge. Ruined by a little film called *Saturday Night Fever*, you may've heard of it. Bensonhurst was solid Italian, you didn't have an Italian last name you couldn't even rent an apartment. Bay Ridge was majority Irish but good enough number of Italians, Greeks, Puerto Ricans, Scandinavians. Norwegians in particular. We called the Scandees Squareheads. Anyway. At one time Third Avenue there were more bars within two miles, one on every corner, sometimes one in the middle, and I got into it kinda by accident. Had to do with the Irish Liberation Movement. I did a solid for a dude who was, basically, on the run. Wasn't anything illegal, just, he was being followed and I saved his ass, and he plugged me in. I mean it really wasn't anything, what happened was, I happened to be walkin, there was a bar on the corner, my local, my father drank there thirty years, one of my older brothers had an aptartment upstairs from the bar and drank there, it was a corner bar so there was a corner entrance and a side entrance on the block I lived in, they called it a family entrance. Anyway my old man used to get up before the sun and by the time I walked home from school he was already back. So what he'd do is, do the grocery shopping and sit in the bar and I'd come in, take his grocery packages, and when we got home, I'd give em to Ma, she'd make dinner and we'd call the bar and say. Dinner's ready come

home now. That's how it worked. Then one day this fucking donkey grabs me and asks me, you know, Kern, do you know the laundromat over by 5th and I say yeah I know what you're talking about, and the guy says, you gotta go in there cuz Allen's stuck in there he thinks he's being followed, you gotta go in there he thinks it's British intelligence, or the FBI. He said, go in there give him your clothes, cuz we kinda looked the same I guess but I was younger, and give him your bike and then hang in there for half an hour and walk out. And I did that, they saw me walk in and saw me walk out and it worked and he got away. The Irish bar owners thought I was a good kid, let me come in after school, they let me carry ice up, stock the bar. I was into the hardcore punk scene, I had a band, was in the graffiti scene.

Revs and I knew each other from New York hardcore. Lived in the same neighborhood, I knew him by his real name, I was 68th & 2nd, he was 82nd and 5th, Brooklyn mind you. His crew was getting good at throwing stuff up, and everyone had a band, I think there's an E.P. out there somewhere, we got together much later actually and did it. Revs is in some ways a very singular guy—he does it his way—but he's very much about seeing things through, and it always stuck in his craw we never saw it through, so a decade later we got everyone together, rehearsed, recorded. One of the tracks was a bit of a hit, got some play on the college stations.

We started bombing trains together, totally under his wing. I didn't have any talent, he had talent. He

used to do pieces, big pieces, right, and he'd let me fill in for him, put white here red over here, that's how we did it. We're still friends, still close, you know. We grew up together. Very private, very singular guy.

So that's how I came of age. In the 90s, after I came outta the Army—I was in for a few years, psycho Vietnam vet drill instructors, that's a separate story—but in my twenties I got into, they called it alternative comedy, sketch comedy stuff, and lo and behold, I have a friend. Well I used to. He said, Man you do everything fuckin backwards n twice, most people go into that world and it takes them years to develop n shit but I guess I had a bit of a character? I had quick success I was literally gettin flown to LA, first class, did a pilot for Castle Rock, it didn't get picked up but I'd never made so much money. I made 15 grand for a week's worth, you know what I mean?

I did a couple spots on Conan O'Brien, *Law & Order*, this and that. Inmates, they'd think they knew me but they wouldn't know why, it was cuz they watched all the cop shows where I did bit parts. They'd keep saying I know you from somewhere, do you have a brother who works upstate? But you don't want to give them personal info so I'd make up stories. I'd say that I used to be an auxiliary policemen, the kinds you see at parades blocking off traffic. They're like buffs, they tend to be on the doughey side. Or I used to tell people I was a detective in the auxiliary police, a plainclothes. Or whatever absurd.

Anyway. Many fuckin chapters, you know what I mean? In this life. It was an exciting time. Starting to get into the Giuliani era but it was still New York, you know what I mean? A lot of authentically interesting people around, I was tending bar, I remember, when was it, the Lehman Brothers shit? 2008? I remember this guy came in, shirt and tie, he came in and asked for a manger I said, you're lookin at him, he hands me a resume, he's from Princeton and shit I'm asking, what the fuck are you doin here? He said, I'm \$160k in debt. I knew the times were changing for good.

The way I got into corrections, I'd been doing judo a buncha years, and my wife, my wife is Japanese, and she was working in Orlando for a while for a Japanese tourist agency, they really hold your hand, make sure people meet you, very service-oriented. And the company, I think the base was up here, and in dojo, everyone was really tight, all the regulars, it was something like surfing I really got into. Surfing's just like breathing. You take it in and out. Anyway, I'm one of those people, I've got that idealism in me, if I start believing in something I'm all in, you know?

Anyway, she went to college with this dude who was, you know, been doing judo since he was 5 years old, he was a motherfucker, really good on the mat, but he was here on work visa, for a Japanese company. We would go out drinking and stuff like that, few years but then he got called back to Japan. But she'd lost her connect so she had to stay in a hotel and stuff, and I was being a nice guy just offering, Oh you can stay with me! Little did I know I'd never get rid of

her. Then she starts working for Japan Airlines at JFK, and I'm coming down to Rockaway all the time to surf, I mean in the summertime, right now? It's not Rockaway it's Rockapulco you know what I mean? And we're living in Bay Ridge, and it got to a point where, what I'd do is I'd surf, and JFK is, well you can spit on it from here. And I'd pick her up after surfing and bring her home, and we got married in 2007. Well first we moved to Rockaway, she suggested it, I said, fuck yeah, I can surf year round. What happened is I was hustling, teaching surfing acting bartending, any side gig available, you know what I mean? Taught kids how to surf, tried to turn them on to it, you know? It was good for them. I got a lot out of it, mentally wise, I wanted to pass that on. Tended bar a little. Owner in a bar I worked at used to say, Joe, I raised the price a nickel and took fifty cents of abuse. So they kept the prices real low like. Place was his garden. He'd sit there wash the glasses way you'd bathe a child. Newspaper spread all over the bar. Wash one, read a little, wash another. Man just wanted to be a friend to all men.

And we eventually. Well she did all the work. She got pregnant, is what I'm telling you, G, and what happened was we were on her insurance, just for the two of us, paying \$650 a month, just the basic bare bones fucking bullshit you know. And I was like, fuck man, I'm 40 whatever, 43? And I was like, yo, I gotta grow up, I can't be a bohemian anymore, so what I did was. And this is the backwards and twice thing. Where I grew up, Brooklyn, very blue collar,

with my daughter's school, you walk in the door and there's five Nobel laureates on the wall, people of great renown. Ruth Bader Ginsberg, Chuck Schumer and his sister Fran, went there. Jewish neighborhood that puts a lot of emphasis on education. Whatever. But where I grew up, a working class neighborhood that put lots of emphasis on union jobs and stability. My friends, if they didn't have a trade like carpenter, which usually runs through the family, you take you know the fireman test, the police test, the sanitation test. Anyway I took those but I didn't take those, you know, but now I'm 40 and I can't do any of those, I'm too old for the fire department or the police. Anyway I didn't wanna be a copy but I took the tests I could but corrections is the first one, and they paid the most. That's the only job that'll give you money when you don't want it, cuz if no one comes unlocks that door you don't go home, you know what I mean? I think the starting salary was \$43k when I started. I made \$100k that year. Because they wouldn't let me go home. You know what I mean? And all my health dental etcetera went from 650 to zero. Maybe a \$20 copay here and there. You don't need any referrals, you wanna see a specialist, you see a specialist, you know what I mean? My daughter gets born and my life really changes.

There was always a Middle Eastern presence in my Irish Italian neighborhood growing up. The Italians good bless em taught us how to make a good meal. The Middle Easterners were overwhelmingly Palestinian, Syrian & Lebanese Christian though.

Well, in my local watering hole. There was this old guy. Archie Bunker type. Whenever he'd come in I'd be thinking, ah fuck, I'm gonna have to listen to this moron. His kids were grown and out of the house. He rented his basement apt. To a Muslim family that were full blown Muslim. Mother wore the hijab. Strange cooking smells wafting into this guys home. The whole 9 yards. The father drove a taxi 14-18 hrs a day to support his family (bunch of kids I think). Everyone of that Mensa meeting of a bar would break his balls: "How's the Bin Laden family?" &c. This of course would send him into a bigoted diatribe.

One day he comes in and it's the same kind of trolling from his peers. He's different though in a key way. He says the father—a taxi driver, probably working twelve-hour days seven days a week—had been in an accident and was in hospital now, no income, no insurance. He says (to my amazement) "What am I gonna do? Throw them into the street? The guys a hard worker..."

Juxtaposition: I'm bartending in a gentrifying area of downtown Brooklyn pre-Barclays center. It's an old time (dive to transplants) bar. The vast majority of patrons are now newer Brooklyn residents. Very woke, very progressive, whatever you want to call it.

Never a bigoted statement unchallenged.

Yet, when they start talking about the brownstone they bought from a family of color who bought it generations ago when the neighborhood was redlined, the joy & euphoria they expressed about

how they got the place for 1/5 of what it was currently worth was nauseating to me.

As my mom used to say: I got no answers only questions. Or as another harelippped old timer put it: Once you think you got the answer, they change the fucking question

I thought I'd be the oldest by far at the Academy, but there were older guys in their 50s, those are the guys that thrive in the chaos. I remember this guy in his 60s, he'd been a detective, a good detective, and he was renting a spot in Brooklyn that was 2400 a month, and his wife took everything in a nasty divorce and he said, I gotta go back to work. The older guys did much better on the job, they knew how to keep their head. You start in your twenties you'll be drinkin. Or you'll try to do everything by the book, which is a disaster. Or you'll get into it with guys, take it personal just cuz you don't like some guy, just cuz he mouthed off at you said Fuck you cracker. These motherfuckas can talk, I mean I'm from Brooklyn but these guys rap, they can really verbally slice you up. When I grew up you'd go outside to fight but with my mouth? Nah. These guys they want you to get fuckin hot. In part cuz the city, it pays out fuckin millions if a guy slips n falls, they always settle they never take it to court. But I'd stay cool and they'd you know be screaming in my face, three guys in your face twice your size and you look at em in the eye like, What's up man, I can see you're upset. You wanna sit down for a coupla minutes and relax? They'd say, Imma fuck you up man I'd say, what better time? No one's

here. I'm all alone. What are you doin talkin, huh? Getting calmer as they get excited.

The turnover is insane. I don't know the exact figures but let's say three out of four don't make it past probation. You gotta embrace the suck. Guys quit during OJT while still in the Academy. After you know, a week? A day? Spent shadowing officers. Usually in minimally dangerous areas, cuz they're new. So. You get the picture. Doug Henley who was a senior editor for *The Chief*, the civil service paper, called certain jobs like FDNY EMT, "meat grinder jobs." DOC he told me was a meat grinder plus. General public is completely clueless. To them Rikers is out of sight out of mind.

When you're in the Academy, what they're teaching you is what's in black and white. This is what the law and the Department says the job entails. Which aren't always the same thing. Jurisdictional stuff, a city council always stickin its nose in. But you get two textbooks, New York Correction Law and New York Penal Law & Criminal Procedure Law. When you get your shield you have to pass two tests, to show you understand your powers and responsibilities as an officer. That's within the first three weeks of your training. Then they start teaching you DOC policy, which is very often at odds with the penal and criminal procedural law. I tell people, keep these books. Lemme see, I've got sticky notes on em, my eyes are so bad... "Part 2.20, Powers of Police Officers. The person designated in... Shall have the following power. The power to make warrantless arrests... The

power to use physical force and deadly physical force in making an arrest or preventing an escape pursuant to section...”

I always kept them because, what they don't tell you, is if it's not written—the DOC has its own narrow and ambivalent policy and definitions—I'll give you an example. There's this one time, I'm coming onto the floor, I'm relieving this guy and this captain, she was so fucking infamous, one time we were trying to leave and they were so understaffed, everyone had already done doubles and it's absolutely illegal to make you do a triple. At the same time, you can't close the jail, you need people. So she was in a tough spot but she wasn't handling it right cuz she's a fucking big mouth. That's how they... Sometimes you'll see dogs, people walkin dogs, they got like a pitbull and a poodle and the poodle's the one always yapping, and the pitbull goes along with it?

I was in the lockerroom, I think I had another tour to do, I said, What's the line? They said this ain't the line to leave, this is the line to beat the shit out of the captain. Other captains had to come, deescalate. Every fight I've seen in public between officers, it's the women. Men, if you've got a problem with another CO, you wait til you're in a lockerroom where there's no cameras, and then you pound it out. That happens often, often enough. You feel disrespected by another officer or something. But the women are vicious, they'll set your fucking locker on fire. Invariably someone grabs a wig or hair extension, it comes flyin off. Then both of em need to be transferred to other

channels.

But she didn't know how to talk to people. It's as simple as this. You can't leave a post unmanned. These guys are locked in there, if there's a fire or a gas leak, you can't walk off post, even if you've been there 18 hours, you wanna go home and see your kid. But this is the job. And instead of just being like, Hey I know this is fucked up, I been here too, we'll try to get you a relief as soon as possible, but there's nobody coming in.

It was a joke, You'd go, get any sleep? They'd say, yeah on the drive home and the drive back. People would crash into lampposts.

"See that guy in cell 1? He doesn't go to rec today." I say OK, what happened? "He's a disrespectful piece of shit, is what happened." She was Dominican big fat ass tight pants. I say, OK cap. Now this is like 6 in the morning. Now it gets to be 2 in the afternoon. In the meantime, another captain's come, he was real well respected, elder statesman of the captains, and he says, He how's it goin, what's goin on, peace love and hair grease. That was his line. He was bald and always drunk. He said, Everything alright? I say, I've been told this guy can't go on rec. He goes, He been bothering you? I say, Nah he's been sleeping all day. He says, No problem, let him out. So she comes back. I'd been working since 11, midnight the night before. She comes in and she's running rec and she's banging on the fucking glass and she calls me into the bubble, there's another officer in there. She goes, What'd I tell you this morning? What'd I

fucking tell you? What the fuck is that guy doing out? She's dressing me down, talking to me like I'm a fucking child telling me, You're gonna go out there and put him in the fucking cell. I go out, I look in the book, because what happens is, when captains come they write in the book— "Captain toured area. Officers alert. Everything seems OK." There's a longer one they write in the morning. She hadn't written about the guy not going to rec, because it's illegal! So I hold the book up to the window, she punches the fuckin window, all, You're gonna regret that. She was always calling her boyfriend on her cell phone which is against the rules. Her boyfriend was also her subordinate, you're not supposed to be fucking your subordinates. So I go, You want me to write? I got plenty to write. They give you illegal orders but they never write it down. If it didn't get written down it didn't happen. Red ink. You're just falsifying documents. You read back a few pages, you'll get a sense of how to write. Medication refusals. Twelve out on rec. The whole story's written. If a captain sees something that needs correction, they'll underline it. I'd always write under captains' comments "Read and understood." But there's just illegal orders being given all the time, captains have a lot of power over you, if there's a good post or a shitty post, whatever.

I kept the textbooks in my locker so when I'm writing a use of force report, like, here's the thing. They don't have power of consent. The biggest toughest dude you've ever seen in your life can come within inches of your face and say, I'm gonna

rip your motherfucking lungs out, and you have no recourse. You can't throw the first punch you can't spray him. However, if that same guy says, CO I'm having chest pains, you gotta take that seriously. You wanna see people with chest pains? Have a lock-in. There's a gang war between Trinarrians and Bloods or whatever, everyone's locked in from 7am to lunch at 1300, nobody comes out. You wanna see people with chest pains? What do you do? Call a medical emergency for 30 inmates having chest pains at the same time? They're gonna hang up on you. If you can't win, you gotta learn how to navigate it. Relax man, what you want, some cold water? Yeah man, I want some cold water. Usually you'll go to a guy you semi-trust, you say, I'm gonna let you out for fifteen minutes, run the faucet til its real cold, get everyone water. If they see you doing it on camera they can sanction you for it, and some of em will. But they've been there themselves, they know what you're doing.

What you're being asked to do is the impossible. Constantly. Following the law is literally impossible. No one is following it. It would make everything Hell if you did. Or you're getting illegal orders from your superiors. It's an impossible job. That's why even the best COs, their style's only gonna work 60, 70% of the time. You're dealing with so many personalities, mental disorders, hatred, like you can't fathom.

So when you're writing a use of force report—"Inmate refused orders, picked up a logbook, slammed it on the desk, told me he was gonna hit me

on the head; I told him to cease and desist, otherwise chemical agent would be deployed; he ignored my warnings and aggressed; I gave him one two-second burst of chemical agent.” They get their report, they say, that wasn’t three feet, you’re losing vacation days. So I’d always add stuff from the state, from the textbooks, because if you don’t know that stuff, they can—the Department can sanction you, but there are things, like the thing that got me out when I was fighting for my life—If they wanna terminate you but you know your powers as a Peace Officer, they can sanction you but they can’t indict you or throw you in jail, because it says in black and white legalese, this is your power as a Peace Officer.

What has to be understood about DOC with its innumerable directives and rules & regulations is that, at the end of the day. The whole job is about falsifying documents. If it’s not written down on paper, and yes. We still use pen and paper for everything. It didn’t happen. If you wrote it did, it did. A decent Captain tours each of their assigned areas at intervals. So, you should see them every two hours or so barring unforeseen circumstances. And, there are always unforeseen circumstances. But some captains won’t even tour. Just sign your logbook saying, you know, Tour completed, All good. Some have steady officers they trust, they’ll have those COs sign their books for them in captains’ red ink, and there’s almost always a red pen on post for such occasions, stashed away. More than half the captains reek of booze.

There was this news story recently. This kid,

he became a police officer in 2020, and they'd just arrested him for workers compensation fraud, quarter million bucks or something, for injuries sustained in the 2010s at Rikers. I wouldn't even file for comp when I got hurt, too much of a pain in the ass going to PT three days a week. You have to submit endless paperwork, injury report, use of force, and then the captains have to spend two hours out of their fucking life to type shit up and testify. I'd always bribe captains who do workers comp paperwork for you, ask em what do you like to drink, get Captain Gordon a bag filled with Hennessy.

But there was endless corruption kid, if I was working in a gang house, and an alarm went off, place smells like OC. if you sent a slip in saying you got sprayed you could file a slip with Geico and get fifty bucks. But I'd get calls all the time, mostly from the better areas, mental health areas with their own nurses, treatment associates, whatever they called them. I'd get calls and they'd be like, Yo what time was that alarm today? I'd say, Oh it was at 12:15. They'd go, What was the name of that inmate? And I'd know the guy wasn't there, he'd want the name and case number of the inmate, which captain came. That's all they'd need and Geico would send up fifty bucks. Now I'm not saying this guy filed \$200k of Geico slips, but there's a lot of this stuff, same with the whole world, Congress is full of insider trading. Why do you think Presidents spend a billion dollars to get elected to a job that pays \$100k? It's all graft and graft man.

These institutions man. It's fucking 1984, I almost got a tattoo on my arm saying "Fair is foul and foul is fair," like in *MacBeth*? Because that's what life's like in there. Everything is inverted, everything is upside down. It's almost a throwaway sentence in that play, but it's so true in the jails. Not to mention the line comes next, "fog and filthy air." One way you can tell if someone's been in Rikers is asking them the first sensation that comes to mind. 95% of inmates and officers will tell you... It's the smell.

So the older officers with steady houses, they have something called The Program. In 1984, Orwell says the political prisoners were treated real bad, and it was the criminals who were given special privileges and inducements and they'd mete out punishment for the officers. The Program was run in the jail with the young kids. They'd give the kids cookies and pizza if they policed their fellow inmates so the officers wouldn't have to get out of their chair wouldn't have to lift a finger.

Basically, from my point of view, all inmates are liars, and all of them are 99% of the time lying. Even when it didn't matter, just to stay a step ahead of you. And I get that, because I come from a family like that, we always owed money. People would call, my mother was always dodging bill collectors and shit. Teaching the kids to lie for them. My wife would ask me if I was drinking some beers with friends, I'd say nah nah, she'd say, I can smell it on your breath! I'd say, Okay you're right, I just didn't want you to worry

because I had the car and was driving. It's just guys following incentives, guys who didn't get raised to know any different.

Anyway, after Academy, you get posted, and most of the COs, when they got to Rikers—and I understand why they did it—they decided to sign up for a steady post, same house every day, dealing with the same guys. To me that was... there's no way I was doing that, no way I was spending 20 fuckin years staring at the same brick wall. I always wanted to move around, I stayed miscellaneous which meant I did anything, like fuckin *Taxi Driver*, anything anywhere. Plug in to vacay, work in a clinic, or you crap out in a shitty house, but I wanted to see how the sausage got made, I really needed to see it. When you're just in one house you don't see the whole picture. You don't understand how the clinic and the sanitation and the mail room all fit together. You do sanitation you realize these are the guys move all the drugs around. The guys who work in the mess hall. They gotta go to all the rooms, you know, to do the garbage or food or whatever. I told people, You don't do it in front of me, I said, If I see it I'm not firing you, You're firing yourself. If I'm seeing it you're not good at it. The best guys the best workers were the Latin guys and they hustled. The blacks were lazy and the whites were entitled.

A lotta officers who get jammed up, it's about money. You're making \$150k. Never home, wife or yourself or both start fucking someone else.

Divorced. Now that woman has your house, that you're still killing yourself to pay for, plus child support. Let's say an inmate wants a carton of Newports and weed, whatever. They'll pay you \$600, \$1000 bucks every week off the books. Easy to fall prey. But once they got you you're owned by that gang. Before long you're bringing in H & those clay Exacto scalpels that may end up in your coworkers neck.

Place is loaded like a fricken bodega. A k will get you a cellphone in, no problem. Usually through a dirty officer. Maybe they want a quiet steady house and reckon a cell phone'll help. Making a deal with the devil rarely works. Pretty soon someone'll get pissed off at you and you will get caught.

People take weapons and hard drugs real serious. Fentanyl's near impossible to detect. Heavy drug users are there in dorms, and if you're there, you see someone in bed too long you gotta shake their foot. You've always got narcan on you. The guys that are high could be dying high, barely breathing, and you hit em with narcan, and as soon as the shock wears off they wanna kill.

On the intake form, they ask your drug of choice, and the guys always put down double their dose, if they're on 5 a day they'll say 10, so when they taper you down, whether it's methadone or suboxone, you'll kinda get high even if it's not enough. Alcoholics can die from detox so they put em on medications, librium. Guys addicted to benzos, detox can kill you, you'll go into all kinds of seizures.

If you have an addict withdrawal, the squeaky wheel'll gum everything up, you got a quiet house and suddenly this guy's saying he feels like he's dying, bitching and moaning.

And of course sometimes they're puttin on. I gotta tell you something about the acting, man. I learned—never mind me—think of the best actor you've ever seen Meryl Streep. None of them compare to these guys. I've seen guys pretend to have a seizure they're laying back white foam's coming out of their mouth eyes back of their head and you're feeling for a fucking pulse you're thinking shit they're gonna die and then they get them outta the house and 20 minutes later they come back screaming their heads off like Fuck you, they need dope. Like motherfucker! These guys are the best actors, and it is all an act. If you're not that guy you've gotta pretend to be that guy in order to survive. You gotta put on the show, put on appearances. They used to say, you know, there'd be wrongful police shootings, high crime areas and mistaken identity and shit like that. And then you find out the cops shot the wrong dude, some serious misconduct, and you'd be like, Why'd you do that? They'd say, There was a description this guy fit the description. Meanwhile this kid, maybe he's going to school and studying but he wears baggy pants and the hat to cosplay, to look like a thug, cuz if he has his pants pulled up and doesn't look like a fucking thug he's gonna get knicked.

The only thing the job's got to offer is money. They give you money even when you don't want it.

People'll get outraged in the *Times* like, this officer made \$300k last year, but you know how he made that money? They forced him to take it they wouldn't let him go home. That man had the most hellish year imaginable. This isn't Adams giving out tickets to the Knicks game. The jail must be staffed. Guys are locked up, if there's a fire or shit hits the fan, so if there's a staffing shortage, if someone misses a shift or the flu's going around, you're not allowed to leave. During COVID, we weren't doing overtime, we'd stick around so long it was straight time again, totally illegal, you'd have been working twenty hours. I remember Captain Mitchell would buy a hundred burgers for the team and just go around and distribute them, bought them out of his own pocket, just wanted to get hot food in his people. Great stand-up captain. But they'll keep you there indefinitely, they'll set up cots have you working round the clock, guys sleeping four hours and back on a shift, I mean, you're locked in there with them. You're an inmate too, you're not allowed to leave. I'd sleep in my car just to get some privacy, and cause it stunk to the wazoo. You can't get it off your clothes. Place smells like shit and blood and ammonia. The BO...

One of the first places I remember going to, this house has gotta be one of the worst places I ever worked. They always give you the terrible houses early on, after Academy. They want you to see the worst first. If you can make it through the worst houses you'll do fine, it'll only get better by the time you get

to the dorms, you know, people with substance abuse problems, burglars. Small-timers.

The way this house worked, they got juveniles, up to 17 or 18, and then young adults, like 19 to 22 or something. Jail across the street had the juveniles. These kids are all energizer bunnies, man, they don't sleep, all they do is fuck around all day. You turn around they're cutting someone. Really violent really crazy. One of the first days I worked there—usually you take a count first, go in and they got floor cards with their information—next of kin, where they live; red if they're known to carry weapons, white if they have a medical condition—heat sensitivity, methadone, diabetes, you name it. If they have a red card, they can't be moved without handcuffs and a couple officers. Some particularly notorious inmates need an escort by the Emergency Service Unit if they leave the building.

So you gotta count the cards. You don't wanna have 31 bodies and 30 cards. Cards follows inmates everywhere they go: if they're in the kitchen, if they leave the building for a court date. So you count the cards and you count the razors. They give out BIC single-shaves. You have to be very careful. They'll take the tinfoil wrap on chewing gum and replace the razor, put the plastic back over it, pass it off when you're real busy, trying to do three things at once. Cuz if a razor's missing, you're responsible. They'll raid the house, turn everything over, special search. No one wants that.

Anyway, what happened was, soon as I got there,

I was in there, and I remember this officer, he was small, glasses. And he went to unlock the door, 8AM lock-out. And this guy just fucking hit him, as hard as he could. Knocked him out standing up. Glasses flying across the room. We all ran in, grabbed the guy, threw him on the ground, he didn't resist, we put him in the dayroom, were pretty rough about it. Turns out he was scared for his life, cuz these kids would cut you up outta boredom, it was all drama. He just wanted off the floor, get transferred to enhanced security. It's not true solitary but you'll be put in an area where it's tough to get to you. Whereas the kids are just running around the day room torturing people, fucking with em, taking their food. He knew he had a mark on him and that was the surest way of getting out. An inmate on inmate fight? They'll go to the clinic, getting writ up, and then it's back to the house. But you hit an officer you're transferred.

The poor kids. The poor dopes. They don't stand a chance. This guy's on the phone, he's laughing, he's all proud he goes, Yo my boy, he's just like his pops, my woman was telling me he threw his desk out the window, went at his teacher. Probably in second grade or something. There's lineages, generational trauma and stuff, it's a whole subculture. I like Zohran but we used to call politicians like that Hug-a-Thugs. I remember this public advocate came into Rikers, he ran right out. Guys were tossing milk and shit at him. He came out like, the conditions are horrible, it's such a racist system. It's unbelievable, you know? It's this lumpen proletariat, man, they don't have good

intentions and they're not good for society, and their targets are single moms and one another. It's one of the reasons lefties don't get a lot of traction among law enforcement. So damn bright-eyed about these people as innocent victims. Believe me, these guys are actors man. Like, they're stupid? But you should see some of the weapons I confiscated. Officers, if they confiscate stuff lying around the house, they'll hang on to em, cuz these things'll get through metal detectors, they're super sleek and you might need it for self-defense. And these guys, every conversation is a transaction, every interaction someone wins and someone loses, and you feel it. It's really hard for white women who are psychs and clinicians, cuz they totally get played, they're so naive. They'll be all super charming, and when she's outta the room, they'll be laughing about it, like Yeah I'll be fuckin her in six months. Now, if they're along long enough they get jaded, don't get me wrong. But they're fresh meat, the new hires, these nice white women who come in with this bright-eyed idea. It's like I'm telling you. All the jail's a stage.

When we were teenagers, we didn't have much either, but it sure beat that shit. True, you could get the shit beat outta you if you went in the wrong neighborhood, strayed onto the wrong block.

Last of six kids. Eight people including parents a dog and a cat living in a two bedroom Brooklyn apt.

Father worked real hard to keep us together, he had a 6th grade education. Born the year the

Depression started. Always put food on the table, three meals a day. Sometimes just bread and butter for lunch, we called em Chinese sandwiches. To me, he was a monumental presence. Tall guy, 6'2" and stoic, not a lot of laughter, Clint Eastwood type. If I spoke disrespectfully to my mother, there wouldn't be a warning. Didn't have a lot of words, didn't have a lot of ideas how to discipline beyond the fist. You were getting punched out, you took it, my older brother Joe stood there took it like a heavy bag. Me, if he gave it to me good once, one big punch, I'd let myself get knocked over, I'd sprawl out, which he didn't respect much, he'd hold me up by my hair, hit me. He broke his hand on my head once.

He'd hang out in this bar after hours. There was a bookie who was a made man in the LCN, real-deal gangster, La Cosa Nostra. Composite character in Good Fellas or somethin. Better be good, or be good at it. Most of these guys, locked up, ain't good at it. They suck at being criminals. But let me tell you, they become excellent at being full-time inmates. Anyway, my old man was a bit of a guru actually, I remember a member of the Angels coming and paying respect at his funerals, said Pa talked him outta doin stupid shit.

Lotta characters in that bar. One of em, Aldous, would walk in with a butcher's robe and a pencil behind his ear, and he'd ask what people wanted, and he'd go rob the ACM, the meat factory you know. So we had steak a lotta days in a row. I remember getting sick of steak I chopped up the steak, threw it in

a paper bag garbage, with the dog shit and whatever, and my dad made me eat it.

It wasn't the easiest upbringing. Never any adults around, totally unsupervised. Got abused a few times, sexually I mean. Still working through that stuff. The first time... Well, If my mother hadn't had six kids she'd have been a Broadway star. She worked for guys, it was a small production company, and she got to know a buncha people, she knew Bob Fosse personally. I used to do my homework sometimes in the local theater. She was always watching Fred Astair and I thought tap-dancing was cool, I started going to lessons, my mother got tap lessons for me and now I had to walk down the street in tap shoes all the guys are making fun of me.

Guy who was probably a chickenhawk went, You know this kid he's a natural, the way he moves, turn-out, I can turn him into a great ballet dancer. I go, no fuckin way, like I haven't already had my balls broken enough for tap dancing. And I remember watching TV in the living room and I'm sitting there and my parents are around the corner at the dining room table, and he couldn't see that I could hear them talking, they thought I was watching TV. My mother's saying, "You gotta understand Joe, the Joffrey Ballet is the biggest, we'd never be able to afford to send him here, you gotta talk him into it, but he'll do it if you tell him to." He turns around the corner, looks at me, takes a long drag from his cigarette and says. Betty, the boy is strange but he's not fucking stupid. He's not gonna take the subway with dance shoes in

his hands.

My mother put me in to like an NYU senior thesis film or something, that was gonna be shot over ten days near the Rockaways, Atlantic, I was probably twelve or something, and the girl who was the ingenue, this whole gang of kids are obsessed with, Venezuelan with blonde hair absolutely beautiful, eyeliner and Betty Page haircut. It was an off-night and we were watching TV on the couch late at night, everyone else had fallen asleep. She was 18, I was 12, she took me upstairs, of course I was terrified. But you know. It was what it was. I was never mad at her I didn't hold it against her or nothing. I thought I was in love with her.

The next time, this guy in the neighborhood, he was essentially the neighborhood pervert though I didn't know it at the time, and I'd had a girlfriend, my first, and she'd broken up with me and I was really broken up with it. And these guys are experts, they'd seen me moping around, I was blonde, he comes up to me sayin, Hey you live around here, what's the matter. He's giving me tips, if you want women, you ever notice the Puerto Ricans are squeezing their dicks to make it look big in their pants, you're a little underweight, I got weights at the house why don't you come over. I was vulnerable there wasn't much supervision my mother was quite sick. My mother was in and out of the hospital, sick a lot of the time. My father was working all the time. And I took this guy up on it. Thank god he didn't penetrate me or anything. But he had me where he wanted me. Put

his hands all over me. I told my brother and my brother was really fucking, I mean, like, I'm gonna kill this motherfucker, and what's the matter with you? Are you fucking stupid? Everyone knows that guy's... Turned out he died of colon cancer within a year.

And then when I was 14 or 15, there was this woman here at a neighborhood show, did a lot of drugs, lot of cocaine, stuff like that, she decided to school me, she was thirty or something, and that went on for a year, she'd take me to hotels, get me flying, I'd fuck her brains out. To this day that's been, if I trace back, I see a lot of my relationship problems start there, there was a real—I don't have the education to say it—but your right brain and your left brain, I really compartmentalized sex and love, one had nothing to do with the other, and I'd find I'd be attracted to people who were emotionally unavailable, lesbians, I thought girls with short hair were super cute. The ones I ended up in relationships with I'd have a hard time performing because I felt something for em. The less I felt for them the more potent I was, the more they fell for me, and the more I'd push them away. It's followed me my whole life.

And then we were ditching school, going into to Times Square, it was our wonderland. I mean, it was a place you didn't want to be alone. We ran five, six, seven deep. We were thirteen but half my friends carried knives. We'd be in these giant arcades. My friends who looked the biggest, with fake IDs, would go into the local, get everyone a 40oz of beer, you'd spend a day out there smoking weed. One of my

friends found one of the dealer's stashes of blow, it was a lot, in little dime bags to be sold, and we ran into a theater, went up into the balcony, I don't know how long we were there, a fuckin day. We wouldn't do anything we were just kids we'd just chuckle and do crazy stuff. I'm not gonna say there was no titillation involved but you were with your friends. I remember a friend taking plastic bottles of baby lotion, we'd sit in the pitch-black balcony, and we'd squeeze it out, down belown, we'd hear someone yell, Ah motherfucker! Money shot, you know. These were usually kung-fu movies we were at, not usually adult stuff. It would be filled with kids on a Tuesday afternoon, and old creeps. And this one time the movie stops midway, we thought they were changing reels, and the cops come in, cracking down on truancy, and all us little rascals running every way, we get into a back alley, and I run right past this Irish cop, and he yells, Hey you stop! And I was essentially a good kid, so I stopped, and he rolled his eyes like, Idiot, go, we ain't tryna to catch you.

So that's how I grew up. I was a punk rock kinda kid, Brooklyn was rife with these kids, these cugis, these guidos, I was half-Italian but we were at war with em. We were ditching school, going to Times Square, it was our wonderland. I mean, it was a place you didn't want to be alone. We ran five, six, seven deep. We were thirteen but half my friends carried knives. We'd be in these giant arcades. My friends who looked the biggest, with fake IDs, would go into the local, get everyone a 40oz of beer, you'd spend

a day out there smoking weed. One of my friends found one of the dealer's stashes of blow, it was a lot, in little dime bags to be sold, and we ran into a theater, went up into the balcony, I don't know how long we were there, a fuckin day. We wouldn't do anything we were just kids we'd just chuckle and do crazy stuff. I'm not gonna say there was no titillation involved but you were with your friends. I remember a friend taking plastic bottles of baby lotion, we'd sit in the pitch-black balcony, and we'd squeeze it out, down below, we'd hear someone yell, Ah motherfucker! Money shot, you know. These were usually kung-fu movies we were at, not usually adult stuff. It would be filled with kids on a Tuesday afternoon, and old creeps. And this one time the movie stops midway, we thought they were changing reels, and the cops come in, cracking down on truancy, and all us little rascals running every way, we get into a back alley, and I run right past this Irish cop, and he yells, Hey you stop! And I was essentially a good kid, so I stopped, and he rolled his eyes like, Idiot, go, we ain't tryna to catch you.

Back in the neighborhood there were three social groups. Wasn't strictly racial. But the Italians tended to like disco, El Dorado cars, Cadillacs, gold chains. Saturday Night Fever land in Bay Ridge. Most of the Irish and Norwegian kids were into rock, the uniform was a plaid shirt, radio blasting Led Zeppelin, drinking in the park, smoking weed. And then there were hardcore punk kids, my group, and we weren't in favor with any of those groups. But they're the

people you grew up with, went to school with. It wasn't violence anytime you crossed paths or nothin. But it could spark.

Nowadays kids call Bay Ridge the Shire, it's still pretty solidly white, southwest of Brooklyn, fair sized Muslim population but it was a fairly safe place to live. Then when SNF came out, which was really shot in Bensonhurst, but they called it Bay Ridge for some reason, and suddenly disco clubs were popping up all along 3rd Avenue, which was my avenue. So my brother's generation, there was some brutal, bats and tire irons type confrontations, my brother got his teeth knocked out. When I had to go to the Puerto Rican area, I had to run for my life, there were dirty gangs with dogs and you were a white gang, you weren't from there. I dated a girl in Bensonhurst, she lived up on like 20th avenue, and we were going to some kind of party, and me n my friend, who looks unbelievably Irish freckles the whole thing, and we got off the train and it was all strict Italian, people were looking at us, it was tense, like, What are you doing here? You ain't from here. I remember going to a coffeeshop to get an espresso or something and when we came out, a bottlerocket, a firework went off right over our head and there were like 10 cugins standing there, one of em had a bat, he was hitting it against the parking meter just staring at us.

City's changed, you don't need me to tell you that. I think the way most people who grew here describe it is pre-Giuliani New York and post-Giuliani New York, with the broken window stuff, cleaning up graffiti.

Back in the 80s, the murder rate was comparable to the deaths in Northern Ireland.

Like anything, the City is reactive. DOC is a dinosaur court in a tarpit. Vestiges of the old New York and they don't know how to fix it.

These guys can't make it on the street. It's a hard truth. Half of em got released for COVID and within a year they were back inside. If you're like me, you listen to WBAI, you're on the air-quotes left, it's all Cops are fascist, bla bla, and there's a march to Police Plaza, you're gonna see parents with baby carriages. But at night, the criminal class, the lumpen proletariat are bustin into liquor stores, sneaker stores, using this opportunity to create mayhem. And I talk to people, they go, "You don't understand." No, I do understand.

Anyway, growing up we were a union fam. Taught me that a good union doesn't create more followers, it makes more leaders. That was Norman Seacrook's problem. Imprisoned for racketeering. Very charismatic, could talk Jesus off the cross. Had a cult of personality. Could BS his ass off, got some good things done, sorta cross between Sharpton and Hoffa? But a total Stalinist, you know, he was the union. When he went down on corruption charges no one could step into his shoes, he never groomed his leadership for the contingency.

Corrections has a union obviously, but there's no support, no departmental support, the Corrections union, the conditions are so bad that a union position is for the most part, you're out of the building and

you get to wear a suit and they give you a car... They're always fighting for fucking zeros, this guy beats his fucking wife, this guy crashed driving drunk on the way home. They just can't deal with the day-to-day bullshit, there's just not enough of them. I'm not defending them, I got no respect for them—the leader of the union who's considered the most respected leader—he went to jail for racketeering. It's just another club, it's a racket.

Whole DOC don't protect it's own, they're filled with so many fuckin zeroes. Nobody grows up thinking they wanna be a correction officer. They may grow up thinkin they wanna be a cop, a fireman, and those guys get a lot of public support, they're out in the open, people see what they do. Fireman is a universally heroic job. Police depending who you talk to. But everyone hates the cops til they need one. Same with lawyers.

I'll tell you a story about how little they give a shit. I was in this house, there was this young kid, probably 22 23, but I didn't like the way he was moving, he was scared, he was putting on a heavy... He was walkin hard. Giving everybody the grille, mean-muggin everybody. There was this Polish kid from Greenpoint, he was just a junkie or something, bigger kid, and I'm sitting right there and all the sudden this kid hauls off and punches him in the face. So they both square off and they're fighting and I'm like, Yo stop fighting, they don't stop so I pull out the spray, I go, last warning. Polish kid stops cuz he don't want a spray all he wants is his suboxone

or his methodone or whatever. And I put him in his cell, I turn around and the kid goes, You gonna spray me? He pulls out a razor blade. And like, these tiers, it's like the hallway of an apartment building. At this point we had body cams, so I go, Are you out of your fucking mind? And I blast him in the fucking face, and he drops it. And I always carried handcuffs on me, it's part of your uniform but the department doesn't really want all the officers walking around with them, cuz officers being officers they get lazy, take their belts off, especially their women, hang it off the back of their chairs to get comfy, really fucking stupid, you got your keys and your OC on it and it's just dangling.

So I cuff the kid, call the captain, tell him a use of force. They don't have to send a team, I got the kid, I cuffed him and I put him on the bridge, between the entrance gate and the main door. That's where the bubble is and the bubble's locked. And he's all, "You sprayed me," I'm like, "Bro You pulled on me." A week later, I get a notice of command discipline, they're taking days. Conduct unbecoming of an officer. I go, What the fuck did I do? Apparently I cursed on camera. The guy could've cut my neck! I would've bled out! I was by myself. No way they'd get me to the clinic in time. I ended up beating it but they were looking to take vacation days away. I recovered the weapon, turned it in—it was a skinny thing in a hollowed-out AAA battery.

It's such a fucked-up place. Two times in my life I told someone they were a good officer and each time

they cried, man and a woman. Because no one ever tells you in that place.

I'd always try to be considerate. I'm working with female, I'd always offer them an A post, often they want it cuz they're not dealing as directly with the inmates, but sometimes they don't want it cuz there's more paperwork, phone never stops ringing. Midnights aren't bad. Or I'd say, cuz we were way far from the medical clinic, I'd say, Look man, we're in Siberia. Something happens, the clinic ain't coming or they're coming too late. I was always trying to think, what if you get cut and there's arterial bleeding? We're gonna die up here unless we go downstairs, dump that fucking dumpster out, and fucking wheel you down as fast as a mother. I actually ended up using that on an inmate. Guy was real the hell smashed up. Anyway I remember, I told this CO the dumpster plan, you know, in case something happened to one of us? And the guy told me, I'll never forget, he said, I've been working here two years and no one's ever had a plan.

Or it's like that rookie I told you about. His first thought on the ground was, I hope there isn't a cell door open. Not cuz more people could come out and jump him, but cuz the department was gonna go after him. They'll go back in the footage two hours, they'll look for what you did to make the situation happen. Like, obviously you did something. That's the mentality. And when you're young and you don't know any better, I just felt so bad for this kid.

Anyway, after running around and being a punk

rock kid for a while, I went into the Army. Specifically, I went into the biochemical weapons unit because it was what I was most afraid of. Like if this is how the world ends, I want to understand it. This is still the Cold War you've got to remember.

I took the ASVAB and they said maybe I could be military police, other regular stuff, but biochem man I wanted to know about that, it scared the hell out of me. But after you go through their schools you realize they just taught you enough to get yourself and everyone else killed. That you're totally expendable. You know when that stuff goes off, they expect you to go through it and keep fighting. It's not like, Oh there's been a blister agent attack, let's get the fuck out of here. Naw, you put on your MOPP gear and don't take it off til we're dead or on the other side of this.

Basic training... All the drill instructors were psycho Vietnam vets, this is '85, '86 now. I went from being someone with minimal supervision to being under the permanent watchful eyes of psychopaths. Like being an inmate but worse in some ways, in jail you have rights. You're not even human you're less than human. You see Full Metal Jacket? I remember this one guy, could never do the right thing, kinda like the guy in the Kubrick. Drill sergeants took him one day, he was made to draw his address, they put stamps all over his head, tried to mail him home.

Some COs, they were ex-military. One guy I was very fond of had to be taken off the line in Rikers, I believe he was in Iraq, could've been Afghanistan.

Mortar team, saw a lot of action. His humvee hit an IED, he was the only survivor, woke up covered in four other guys that were his team. That's a guy you want to have your back if things go left. Sometimes he took it too far. I'd go, how'd you pass the psych test?

Lotta Army training was on the cardio side, learning to run in MOPP gear with a mask on and you're just sweating profusely, it's just dropping off ya like rain. The academic side was fairly commonsense, but there were a coupla segments going through it like radiation that were tough. Lotta calculations with directions, way the wind's blowing. Lotta chemistry, memorizing half-lives. They'd just built a live-agent training center down in Fort McClellan Alabama. You'd only know if you'd fucked up. You'd go through these maze courses, like a gymnasium, that was all sealed off. They weren't putting gasses out into the atmosphere. Barriers, paintball type thing you know. One of the more unpleasant things, they wanted to get you used to CS gas. What gets used for riots. And every breath is like breathing fire. I don't know what the long-term effects are, but in the short-term I mean. You kinda get used to it. The idea's to realize that you're not gonna die. It'll hurt like a motherfucker but you'll be fine. Every Wednesday we did a five-mile run in full MOPP gear. Let's say it's May so it's already getting warm down there. And none of the material breathes—that's the whole idea. And as soon as they'd call an All Clear we were all lookin at each other like, Motherfuckers... Because as

soon as you pull down your mask, get that suit off around your waist, they'd release CS gas, and all your pores are just gaping open, and it was pure torture.

I was still so young. It was a funny dynamic down there back then. Alabama 1985, 1986, the Confederate flags were ubiquitous. There were certain bars that were just off-limits. Off-limits to soldiers in general. Off-limits to soldiers of a certain race. I suppose if you were a real downhome redneck you'd've had a chance but. They thought, These soldiers are here to drink our beer and steal our women. It was so poor down there. So the women... You would meet a woman and if a woman's interested in a soldier, not an officer and a gentleman like Richard Gere. Not some air force pilot. But an enlisted man. A grunt. These girls that'd show up are trailerish. And if you get on-base, you get healthcare. You get a steady salary.

I never saw it but I heard about it. Especially blacks. Literally shot dead within minutes of being in the wrong bar. Whereas the girls down there, the real trailer types. Let's put it this way. None of them were the homecoming queen. Few extra pounds here and there, you know what I mean. Maybe they didn't have all their teeth. I mean real poor. They were the most libertine about hooking up with a black guy. Soldier's a soldier. This guy'll get me the fuck out of here. I can end up in Italy, Korea, Germany. Just by living with this dude.

The interesting dynamic was the split. All the white southern guy. Most of them were already married, even at the age, and with kids. You'd say, What're you

doing this weekend? They'd say, We're gonna rent this hotel room here and drink a bottle of Jack Daniels and play cards. That was a real revelation to me. The southern African Americans that didn't get along with the northern blacks. Found em real uncouth n shit. I think that's changed with you know the real hip-hop era but back then. Back then all southerners, regardless of race, would answer each other Sir and Ma'am. Not even military guys, civilians. They were extraordinarily polite. And so they all had a lot of disdain for the northern city guys.

There were three of us from New York, a white kid from Bensonhurst, a black kid from East New York, and a Puerto Rican kid from the Bronx or somethin. But then there was a mix of people, all mix of races, Mexican guy from LA, black guys from Chicago, and we all hung out together. A, because no one was hanging out with us. But also cuz we all had that city mentality, like let's go barhopping. Some wanted to go to club-type bars, some of us like me just wanted to go to the one across the street, has a pool table, good enough.

My best friend was a guy from Forsythe County Georgia. Town of Cumming. In the mid-1980s there hadn't been a black guy living there since the turn of the century. When supposedly a white lady got raped and they strung up a buncha them and the rest got outta town. Never came back. Nor were there any Catholic churches. The Klan used to stand on corners and give out literature. But me n him became pretty tight. I think it was just mutual

interest in how different of cultures we came from. I thought all these guys would ask me stupid questions. Oh do you carry a knife, do you carry a gun grabbing groceries. But no. They were really interested in how steam comes outta the ground in New York. Like the vents? Cuz they'd seen it on *Kojak*. There was all this arcane stuff they'd seen on TV. Wanted to know if it was real. Meanwhile I was asking them questions about stuff I'd seen on *Deliverance*. Lemme tell you, I wasn't goin into the woods alone.

Anyway, this guy's father was a Green Beret or something in Nam who went MIA. I dunno if he was on a mission or after the war said fuck it and never went home, Kurtz-style. But he remembers, when his father was around, the military being a big part of his life. He'd say, The only color I see is green. Meaning army, army green. Not money. Guy retired a bit back, was in an elite unit, 75th Rangers. Went to war. Put in his 20. Now he's an instructor at a gun range not too far. Somewhere in Georgia.

At that point in my life I didn't wanna go to church. I wasn't a believer or nuthin. But I found out real quickly, Sunday was the only way you got left alone. This is training mind you. But if you didn't go to church, you were a freakin heathen, so you'd have to clean the barracks top-to-bottom. So I found religion pretty quick, you know what I mean? And me and this guy, we were interested in each others churches growing up, what they were like. He was a Baptist or something. But I remember he took me to his church

first, and I was just. Gobsmacked. Particularly the black people, they were standing up and swaying and falling over on the floor. I was like, Fucking priest's gonna slap the shit out of these people, they better sit the fuck down fast! But what I liked about it was afterward they gave you Hawaiian punch and cookies. The Catholic mass, I don't think we ever went back after the first time, I think I went full Protestant. The guy was an Army chaplain, Irish Catholic guy from somewhere up east, Boston probably, and definitely a hardcore alcoholic. Red face, smell the booze reekin off him. A real fire and brimstone old school type. Now it's all different, I dunno. This new Pope, Leo, seems to be a real liberation theology type. Like the one before him. Real fuckin hippies. Whereas my sister goes down to New Jersey to this megachurch, it's this you know. This freakin stadium. "God wants the church to be rich" type places. And "Don't feel bad about owning six trucks and all this acreage you never use, these are the blessing bestowed on you as a believer."

Anyway we had a lot in common, and I was underage, and I'd get drunk all the time so I was always gettin in trouble. Every once in a while they'd give you time off, two or three hour pass, go get your hair cut, do your laundry, take your Class A suit to the cleaners. And I'd always try to knock that shit out quick as possible and go to the bowling alley on-post, cuz it gave this 32oz cup of beer for like, eighty cents. And since you're already dehydrated and you're not drinking much you

don't have a tolerance. So I'd come back just fucking smashed. They'd give me guard duty, take away privileges, you're not leaving base. And I'd spend time in the chemical school's library. I got real into watching like, films of MK Ultra-style experiments. These guys, these really you know, crisp flat-top types. Really look like square Army dudes, squared away, and they'd be interviewing em, Staff Sergeant So-and-So, we're gonna give him LSD. First he'd do the obstacle course without it, then they'd dose him and he'd have to do it again. It was hysterical. I just loved watching films like that. They had hours and hours of shit like that. People just laughing and crying into hysteria. They'd show tests of—I can only imagine they were probably guys who—I'm sure they got paid for it. They'd throw an extra couple hundo on your check. Or maybe they were in the brig, they did something, so they were working off their sentence. But they'd show it on their hands. The effects of nerve agents, blister agents, blood agents. Really nasty stuff. Your skin bubbling up. A toxic event. And that was just an eyedropper. You could imagine if it was in the air, if it got in your lungs, how it'd turn your insides to jelly. I came across this book, it was a first edition. This is... 85. AIDS was a thing but nobody talked about it. I don't think Reagan had publicly acknowledged it yet. Maybe my timeline's mixed. But I remember getting this book. I've searched for it for crazy, since. It was called *A Higher Form of Killing*, and it was by these

two guys, a duo like the DNA guys, Crick and Watson. I'd read a first edition and I remembered it so clearly, like I knew the exact page and the line, like it was page 257, I had it underlined. I think it was the 1982 edition. Maybe they moved things around. Maybe they wiped it. But I remember reading so clearly, it was from some appropriations committee minutes in Congress in the 70s. Maybe 1977 or even earlier, asking for money. An unnamed source, a closed committee. Asking for what he called ethnic-chemical weapons. Covert materials for the manipulation of behavior. An ultra-sensitive project exempt from all normal accounting channels. And hidden from all but the most senior officers in the CIA. And that was MK Ultra. All sorts of insane stuff was going down. CIA was setting up brothels, the chicks all had syphilis, and they were dosing the guys with all these chemicals and keeping tabs on them. How many days after did it take them to go to the doctor. Pulling their medical records afterward.

But it specifically said in that book, biological and chemical. And if LSD's the chemical, what's the biologic agent? Now those terms are often interchangeable. But I remember reading that book *The Hot Zone*, on ebola. And that is a real creepy book to read. Ebola obviously don't work well as an agent cuz it kills you too fast. By the time you know you have it it's too late, the survival rate's too low. That shit kills everyone it touches. And I was always a Zappa fan, and Zappa had been saying for years. I

mean Zappa had this song, Imaginary Diseases. And he had this concept record, *Thing-Fish*. Before AIDS blew up. And it was all about this disease that gets invented. In the libretto, the inventor's called the evil prince, he's a spook-doctor type. And this guy starts testing it first on prisoners, black prisoners in particular, and what happens is, it doesn't kill them, it mutates them. Turns them into a Thing-Fish. They start developing duck beaks and their feet get wet and stuff like that. And they start talking like Kingfish, from *Amos'n'Andy*. All that stereotypical slave-era dialect. But they realize the strain isn't working too well with the blacks, it's not doing what we really want, so they start putting it into Brute Cologne. I guess at that time, that was the gays' favorite brand. And at that point it just starts fucking killing em. Killing sissy boys and anyone with a sense of rhythm. And really it's about the death of Broadway. How there's nothing original from Broadway ever again, because they're all killed off. The AIDS epidemic wiped out Broadway. Now it's anything, the music of Billy Joel, the music of Alanis Morissette. They're out of ideas. No one's writing original musicals anymore. That record was really prescient. Not the greatest of Zappa's stuff musically. But the libretto. I mean Zappa put out like sixty LPs when he was alive, and another hundred posthumous, everything from quartet to electronic music. So not every single one's gonna be great. But that one was prescient. And if you read Zappa's biography, he grew up on a

chemical warfare testing ground in the desert or some shit, and his father had experiments done on him for extra cash, they were Italian immigrants. And he was always very critical of the hippy movement. There's something there. Whether you like his music or not, the guy was really really aware, stayed straight, never did more than smoke cigarettes and drink coffee. And knew his contemporaries personally, Janis and Jimi and Jim Morrison. And none of them lived past 27. He thought that stuff was out there to fuck you up. You think they're your heroes but it's the government, keeping you docile, because you're either marching on the streets or you're tryna kick dope or you're doing both. So these are some of the conclusions I came to, in the chemical library.

Anyway. So the deal was. When you're 17 you gotta get signed up. You can't consent. My dad was ready to sign me up for life. My mom made me a deal, she said I'll sign you in to the Reserves, and if you like it you can stay. So I went in as a reservist, and when I came back—six, seven months later. It was practically Memorial Day 86. I went in in November. And at first I just partied. And then I saw, immediately, like. Yo. When I left I'd never heard of crack. And when I came back it was a thing. I mean we were all snorting coke and drinking but. So I joined the AGR, the Active Guard and Reserve. You know all the guys Trump's sending around? Those are AGRs. They're not full-time soldiers. You can't deploy full-time soldiers, it's a violation of the Posse

Comitatus Act. And I was young enough, and they needed the help enough, at Fort Tilden. Which is now the hipster place to go, in the Rockaways. Got these old ICBM bunkers and shit. But we had a base there, and they had an executive officer, a quartermaster, and a logistics sergeant. And they were like, Yo dude. And I was like a PFC at that point, I think I became a specialist there, nearly a Corporal in rank. But I was in an E6 slot, an artillery unit, and I was the chemical NCO even though I was a newbie. So they were like, Yo you understand that all this stuff is undermaintained. Do you wanna go month-by-month, or do a year, do AGR for a while. And I loved it because nobody fucked with me. I could be alone, I'd go into the arms room and just start cleaning rifles. And they were like, Dude, we're not looking for quantity we're looking for quality. If it takes you all day to do one rifle we don't care, long as it's spotless. So I did that probably two years. Maybe not straight—I'd fuck off for two weeks, go visit my brother in Texas or something. And they were cool with it. It was a punch-in, punch-out job. You didn't have to live on-base.

And then I got a pretty good gig in downtown Brooklyn, Meinecke Street Saloon, and they were willing to pay me pretty good money to be the everyman. Busboy, waiter, Sunday brunch bartender, even the manager when the manager was off. That was good money, good swag, you know what I mean? I was getting laid like a fat rat. I was a kid like, you know?

It wasn't til 2001 I became a real Lefty. Most of

my friends they went Right cuz of the shit that went down, like why would this happen to us. I went the other way, like, I need intellectual armor to navigate this shit.

Before that, 2000 I was a Ralph Nader guy, I was his bodyguard for a bit, drove him around. The guy was running for president and they didn't give him any fucking protection. So one of these guys big in his campaign, Karl maybe? He was a lawyer, a public interest lawyer, and one day at an event I was wearing the t-shirt of the judo club I was part of and he chatted with me, said, Hey man as you can see, when we have events like this the NYPD will provide one sleepy overtime detective to travel with us, but he's just there to write the report when someone shoots Ralph in the face. Obviously the two parties hated him. So I was his right-hand guy anytime he flew into New York, some Manhattan church, will you come and stay close to him. When he spoke on Wall Street. I got to spend a lot of time with him, he's probably the closest thing to a hero I have. I really admire the man. All the shit he said that's come to pass. In 2000 his whole thing, his acceptance speech was all about corporate power, and now Citizens United. He was also big in the universal healthcare cause, I'd go to protests and got arrested for that, spent some nights in the can. I was a late bloomer as far as that shit goes, I was in my early 30s, the only other political stuff I'd been to had to do with Northern Ireland, they were trying to deport this guy who fled home to America and was working as a bartender and got recognized.

It wasn't til 2001 I even thought that Americans could be the bad guys. Of course as a hardcore kid when I saw the Reagan Youth, I was 13 I was terrified and obsessed with nuclear annihilation. And then there's all these supergroups, they'd just sing about cars and women. Like dude don't they know the world could end in 60 minutes? That's how long it takes? For the missiles to start landing?

But politics is like anything else. You see it with Zohran. They say running for office is the poetry. Being in office is prose. You make a buncha promises and then you're inside the machine and it has a life of its own. If you don't make a lot of compromises you're not gonna make it.

Give me a second, will ya? I'd like to pour myself a drink before we carry on with this. Lot of memories. Lot of shit coming to the surface. Gotta drive my daughter around during the week, gotta keep clear and straight, but she's gone at a track meet all weekend so it's my big chance to relax.

Rotating shifts was always a crapshoot at Rikers, sometimes you'd hit a real shitty house, but if you were a good worker and you were in a good house—which doesn't necessarily mean the inmates were good, but there—if you were an inmate, inmates are creatures of habit, and if you're used to a CO takin the count and going to sleep, that's your normal, you can do whatever the fuck you want, be up doing whatever, drugs, masturbate, whatever they're doin. If every thirty minutes there's some dude checkin you out, they're like, Yo, you're doing too much. And

I'm like, Actually I'm doing the minimum, if I were doin too much I'd be sayin, all that shit under your bed, clean it up. But black is white and white is black. If you found a good knife, a good banger, you'd hold on to it. You're thinking that's for self-defense, it's not for self-defense, that's an insurance policy—if you go overboard, and they're looking to fire you, you go, This dude pulled this on me.

We wear a banger come what may. It's good to have a piece on you because if you got caught on camera being excessive, you could don survival gloves. Wash the banger off & then wipe the perp's DNA on it by rubbing it with his dirty underwear or even cell blanket & it might save your job as he covertly had it ready to strike before you did what you had to do. It was an insurance policy. Not against the inmate. Against the Department, that was ready to behead you for unlawful self-defense techniques: choking, kneeling testicles.

The whole system is criminal. If you do even a cursory reading of the Wild West. Or take *Unforgiven*. The Sherriff knows all the outlaws. You need a crook to watch a crook. Wyatt Earp and all those guys were all fucking criminals! Obviously it's not ideal because it perpetuates itself. If you're not a hardened criminal when you walk in, you're gonna be when you walk out. You have to adapt.

Anyway. Everyone else on the midnight shift would sleep, and they'd have their alarms on the hour to do their rounds with a flashlight, make it look good. But I had a work ethic from tending, so I was

up and working.

It's easy to get lazy and slothful on the job. Turn off your brain. A lot of people I worked with died of COVID cuz they were diabetic. The whole place is built on landfill, there's a water treatment plant and jetfuel from the nearby airport. In the summertime it smells like shit. And that's the outside. Inside, these are guys haven't showered three months. If you're in a gang house, they'll make you shower every day, but I spent a lot of time, worked a lot with what police call EDPs, Emotionally Disturbed People, or we call MOs, Mental Observation. Not a lot of hygiene. Strong smell. It's really brutal because the clinicians are afraid of them, most of the officers don't wanna work with them. They refuse to take medication. They'd mouth off something crazy and then an Officer would go off about respect, like, It's Ramadan for this motherfucker, he's not getting meals no more, no one talks to me this way. But I tried to treat them like human beings, work with the clinicians. Some of em I could play chess with, they were the most intelligent people—if they were on their meds. They'd read Chomsky n shit, instead of the gang houses where it's just porno mags. They'd tell you shit from outer space. It's entertaining sometimes. But you can kinda talk em down. You could bargain with em for the day room. Some of em.

But if they do snap, they snap hard. You've heard the term retard strength? You can spray em and it doesn't have any effect, something in their brain is just taken over, you nail em right in the eyes—and

you can do that with a guy built like a linebacker for the Giants, 6'5" and 300lbs, could break you in half—you spray him right in the eyes he's a baby crying. But MOs might be wiry skinny and they'll pull a bench out that's screwed into the floor, start beating you with it. The advantage is that it's always 1 v 1. In a gang house, it's you versus all of em, cuz they'll pile on.

But yeah they were interesting guys, they could hold a conversation on occasion. If I saw an inmate who was reading an interesting book, even just 1984, I'd say, You get to that part yet? I'd point something out. Like I'd talk about how, when they make a new dictionary, they wouldn't need thought police anymore, because people will lose their ability to articulate the wrong-thought, their dissident ideas. Try to build a bridge start a dialogue. Or I'd turn a lot of guys onto stuff, we had radios, I'd go, You listen to On The Count? It was a prison advocacy show, and they'd always have people from the Fortune Society, and it was run for people either doing time or who'd just come out.

Sometimes I'd recommend books to other officers but all the COs talked about was how much money you make, how you get taxed, or it's complaining hour, which captain or ADW is out to get you and why. Not especially intellectual conversation. But every once in a while you'd see a guy reading something, *Confessions of an Economic Hit Man*, or *King Leopold's Ghost*, and I'd go, Yo I had to read that shit before I read *Heart of Darkness*, I

needed to understand the Belgian presence in the Congo. And maybe that'd get em on Conrad.

I gave as a gift I think three copies of *Capitalist Realism*. One found it too philosophical. One, he just lost the string when it got into the musical criticism. And one, probably the smartest of the bunch, he was Caribbean. He liked it to the point where, he goes, I like it but I'm reading it on the job and he says, It's definitely something I'm gonna have to digest. He had my first copy, so he had all my annotations, everything I underlined I thought was pertinent.

A lot of officers—it's an aside, but look up statistics from Jamaica, Kingston, see how many police-involved shootings there are. It blows America away. I remember the Caribbean COs, some Trinidad some Tobago but mostly Jamaica, they ruled with an iron fucking fist. They had a real American Dream capitalist streak in them. Like yo man, we bought another house in Queens, we already have a dump in Jamaica I'm gonna fix up, they were true believers. How to create generational wealth. Like, Okay, it can be done here, and this is our path to it. That and education. No one wanted their kids to do Corrections. But they had this mentality of, if I make rank, I keep climbing in here, I keep climbing out there. They weren't in a class-conscience position yet. They were labor union conscious, they knew the union was a good thing, it could get them their contract and vacation days, but they weren't big picture working class. So I didn't make major in-roads

with, you know, the Marx and Engels.

Where were we? Protective custody. Right. Protective custody was a whole different story. More fuckin goin on there than in a bordello. No, amend that—trap house is more accurate. If you see inmates having sex you gotta separate them immediately, cuz they could sue the city and say that was unconsensual, that was rape, the city failed to protect me. You can get a lotta money for that. It's one of the games they play.

Now with trans people, this fuckin city actually gave em a choice, they can go to a male jail or a female jail, pretty soon female prisoners are gettin pregnant and the city's passing out millions in suits, settling up before it goes to court. Some of these guys are puttin out on the street already—they go to the male jail they got a steady stream of customers, livin high on the hog, breakin guys hearts.

The PC houses as they're called, the protective custody houses, a lotta people are looking to play a game. These guys it's not just institutionalized, a lot of these guys, it's even pre-institutionalization, it's like foster care to foster home to a lock-up high school and juvie. They've been infantilized because they don't make any decisions for themselves. Tell you when to get up, give you three meals a day. They don't have an education, they only know how to sell drugs and you can't really do that on the street anymore. I remember when the East Village was an open-air drug market. Blankets on the floor, you'd walk through, the wares spread. I had a junkie guy

one time, I was like Aw man you're back? He looked way older than he was. He said as a joke, Yeah this is the only place I have job security. He was always working sanitation.

People ask about the sex a lot. Jacking off, a lot of that happens at night, after lock-in. You'll hear dudes. Especially if a woman comes on the tier, maybe she's a clinician or an officer. Lotta these black women who work there, they work in tight tight clothes, their ass is huge, it's literally driving these dudes crazy, I think it's a power thing for them, you know what I mean? But I'll hear dudes go—Yo, CO, I gotta go for a sit-down. I'm gonna cash off in my cell for a while. They put a towel up for fifteen minutes. Does fucked up shit go down inside? Sure. It has. It does. Captains raping prisoners. Guys beating off—sniping, they call it, when you aim—whenever the female CO comes by. Not to mentin, you know. Inmates eating feces. Guys getting killed over fried chicken or a box of Frosted Flakes.

When I came in, women had a lot of free time, the men did the heavy lefting. If dudes got lewd with them, rubbed up against them accidentally not accidentally. Or thrust themselves when they're getting patted down, made sure they had a hard-on. The male officers would have to take care of that business. Lot of them lost their jobs, got jammed up behind that stuff, cuz they're gonna get sued. The inmates are gonna sue you. That whole saying, "Snitches get stitches," buncha bullshit. At one time maybe mafia omerta meant something, but these

dudes are all fucking rats, especially if there's a chance of making a buck off it.

With female guards you see more loyalty from the prisoners. Worst thing's to go in a house and see this beautiful women she got them wrapped around a finger it's like fuck they're in love with her. In the dorms you have pantries that are separate from the house. One of the guys said he wanted to get in there to get cold water or something, I'll allow that if it's a hot day, the walls sweating there's no air conditioning in this place, so some dude was like, Yo CO, held up his cup, can I get some? Aight. This woman CO steps in and he fuckin jumps her and the house fuckin saves her, took the brakes off the dude. But you see some loyalty with male captains, male COs too. You're practically living with these guys you gotta remember, I used to play chess with them rap with them, talk to them. You're building a relationship. Or at least a rapport. If you're decent by them they might be a half-ass cool. Maybe.

Does it get sloppy sometimes? Are there prisoner CO relations? Sure, both ways. Male COs, female COs. This is where you know you spend your most of your life, you're there 16 hours a day living alongside them, maybe working the same house. It's where your "real life" is and home is just where you sleep. Infidelity up the wazoo, total cesspool. And if you're a 5/10 on the looks chart, out in the city? You're a Prison Ten. These dudes know how to manipulate certain types of women. They got all the time in the world to listen to these broads and make them

feel special. Aside from that. And, I know this to be true. These are homegirls from the hood. The FBI estimates a third of COs, mostly the women, are gang-affiliated if not outright members. They say the Hells Angels started this but I suspect it was La Casa Nostra. They plant wives, girlfriends with clean records and say: Okay you go get a job at the DMV, you go work in the jails. I even had a good buddy whose family ran a small neighborhood independent newspaper. All the women who were secretaries and answered the phones were wives and friends of mobsters. See, every newspaper gets daily updates from the PD. What they are doing, looking for... Get it? These are inside gals. The department's supposed to scour your socials but if you're careful, well. Or else maybe you have a hook in the department already. I've been to funerals for officers. Young guys. You go in your uniform and are just getting mean mugged by everyone. Casket is blood red. Deceased is in red suit pall bearers, you name it. Supposedly shot in a carjacking with his own gun. Makes your head spin.

But it's a joke sometimes, the female COs they'll pair you with, the captains they'll put you under. I remember this woman, probably five feet tall and maybe weighed ninety pounds, thick Dominican accent, Rosie Perez Spanglish. It's you and her in a house full of thirty gangbangers. How much help you think she's gonna be?

She became an ADW, can you believe that. That's Assistant Deputy Warden. But all the captains are terrible. A couple are great, you'll die for them, you

know? But the median fucking superior. They don't fucking deal with inmates, they just sit there, it's like entertainment for them. All this violence porn. They'll even laugh if an officer gets knocked out, "That nigga shoulda ducked." This one CO would always go, Drive me to the Racino, buy me groceries, in the middle of the workday, all this corrupt shit you needed to do to keep a good post. I remember I was on duty when this alarm went off. So let's say someone's getting bailed out, there's still a lot a lot of paperwork, thick as a dictionary, very redundant, stuff that needs signatures but you never read, that the lawyers want. And there's this house, it's really not a good house, and there's a girl working up there, a young girl from India, and she's up there with all these fucking gangbangers. So you have these different levels of alarms, you have level A which you need a supervisor, level B would be like, use of force, you need a team to come, an in-house team, whoever's around, suit up suit up suit up, put on the ninja turtle outfit. So this paperwork that needed to be signed, to get this guy out of the intake pen, he's been there twelve hours and he's legally free but he can't go til this stuff gets signed. And so I go in the count bubble, in the main corridor, and the Rosie Perez ADW's watching? Anyway, all the fights are going down in the dayroom, and the Indian girl who's working has to go up and down the tier, make sure the doors are locked, move guys around. It's all situational. But she's not suited up, so she's not really part of the operation. The Dominican woman's watching her on-camera with

the other bosses who are no better. And she's tearing this chick apart, because the Indian girl goes to the end of the tier and goes to check the door and five guys jump out, and these are big guys, and she jumps back, and the five guys go running out, they were smoking a joint or something. So she's shredding her, bitch you'd have done the same thing, but I'm standing there I can't hold my tongue like, You should give that girl a medal, she didn't run away, she stood her ground and was counting heads and knew whose cell it was and she took care of it. But this was the kind of bullshit. And because it's a civil service thing, everything's an exam. But I was joking with them, there are these people who are such lousy officers but they're from some shithole where they know, they go back to fucking McDonalds, which is usually the only other job they had that's legit, and they know they're a shitty officer, so they ask, How can I improve my lot? I know, I'll take the test and become a shitty captain. It's all just a fucking multiple choice test, up to ADW, and above that they're commissioned, it's an appointment. Like a detective. They'll do it for police officers killed in duty sometimes, posthumously appoint them to detective for higher pay, help the family out. Lot of those cops are still living at home til they make top pay. Lot of the immigrant families like Dominicans and stuff they're supporting the whole family, putting everybody on their insurance, my mother has diabetes, my father has heart problems, my little sister lacks coverage.

It says something about our society, who we ask

to supervise the worst citizens—or noncitizens—of our country. And New York is relatively high requirements, I had an associate's degree, you need 25 college credits and a high school diploma. The Academy itself will get you extra credits to bring you up to an AAS. But down south, Arkansas, you just need to show you're working toward a GED.

This is a bit of a sidebar, but. Some guys? Won't keep firearms in the house, if they don't have a good marriage, and let me tell you no marriage in Corrections is a good marriage. Because all the wife has to do after a fight is say you pulled a gun on them, and you're fucked. That can happen on the street too, we have concealed carry privileges. I was in the car with my daughter, I got into this altercation, me and this other guy in our cars, he started going I'll fuck your daughter I'll fuck your wife I'll fuck you up. He was recording too, he was recording himself break three laws and then threaten to rape my daughter. Let me tell you, if I was in the wrong state of mind, I'd easily shove that shit up his ass and pull the trigger. So I don't keep it on me. Too easy to slip.

By correction standards, even compared with many of my decent peers, good officers—we've all lost it at some point, gone too far with violence, things like that. Lost control. Man. There was this one time this guy was being, it's hard, see what happens, the thing—the difference between prison and jail is in prison, you have no rights you're owned by the states—but with jails, particularly in New York and liberal areas, these guys are innocent til proven guilty,

and legally that's true, that's good, but these guys brag about the shit they do, in front of you, to goad you, and they try to test you. I don't wanna meander. Lemme just tell you this one story. This one guy, I get called, I don't remember where I was working but the alarm goes off and I've got to get suited up. You'll hear em say You look like the ninja turtles. You gotta put on a vest and helmet with the face shields you know, you grab a stick or a baton, and you're supposed to report to the area. You have, you know—there's two levels, Level A is send a supervisor, you know, cuz this is getting out of hand, the house is turning up, or someone's being disrupted, maybe services can't get through. There's a problem imminent. It's called an anticipative use of force. A Level B, when I started, mean negotiations have failed and it's time to kick ass. You know like? And that's slowly faded away, to where, there's basically not a probe team anymore, there is no Level A. No assessing the situation, seeing if a supervisor can handle it. Maybe the guy just hasn't gotten his mail in three weeks and he was promised he was getting something. In the mail room everyone's inept so maybe you just need a supervisor to handle it, the officers are calling the mail but the mail room's not answering, either cuz they dont give a fuck or they're out delivering mail. So there's this incident, this guy, and he knows he can get away with it cuz he can read the captains. He's talking his shit throwing himself around throwing his body around. The way I was trained, once we're there we're going to war, we're not putting on this sweaty ninja turtle shit to

have a dialogue. And this is gonna be a problem with the narrative, I don't really care about it, but it's why it needs to be anonymous, which is that there's a lot of racial dynamics. A lot of the time the captains are these overweight black females who just talk a lot of shit and make noise and try to coerce, all, Boy you gonna get back in that cell. Some of the guys might listen but some of em dont. And this guy refused a search and said he had a weapon on him. So we're all trying to cajole him in our own ways. I'm like, Yo man, what's up? Are you that afraid of this place? You're saying you're a bad ass but you know when you come into jail you're gonna get searched. If we take your banger, make another one. You gotta do what you gotta do. And he flipped out. That's what it was he was acting the tough guy. But he knew cuz of his status—you get a number status, I can't remember whether it goes down or up, but let's say if you're a 1 or a 2, it's a guy like you or me. Maybe in a subway he had to defend himself and they fell down and hurt themselves. A misdemeanor crime without violence. But the more violence you commit the more points you get. This guy knew he was going to a house where he owed money, and he was trying everything he could to get out of this building, wanted to get under psych evaluation or go to the hospital or anything. There was nothing wrong with him but he was scared. And when I said that he pushed past me and did something I've never seen before, he ran to the front of the intake and jumped over—it looks like a bar but it'd be like, neck high—he hopped that

shit and he was like a fireplug type guy, those are the worst the hardest to deal with, low center of gravity lotta muscle. They're really hard to take down. You'd think it'd be the bigger guys but they're easy, specially if you have a team. One guy goes for one leg one guy goes for the other leg, you spray him and you bring him down. But this guy was like a chubby little Spiderman. He jumped over, I got to him first, and I start bashing his head cuz I know there's no cameras around, and the guy's saying, Just kill me just kill me, you know what I mean? And I was trying to, like. And I caught myself, I stopped. Other people got there, we got him secure, we got his hands behind his back and got him shackled off. I'm shaking saying this cuz I'm re-living it, you know. It's stuff like that, where, I pride myself in being a professional. But how quick that fucking shit went out the window in a chaotic situation. Like, This motherfucker thinks he can do whatever he wants on my time. You don't run this place I run this place. I don't wanna sound like that, like I'm the fucking boss here, but. But that's how it feels in the moment that's what it does to you. I lost it.

I've always been good at not doing that shit. One of the first time, there was the place with no cameras. There was a little room called Drug Interdiction, that's gone now the Feds took that way it's a video conference room. But that was a little room, much better than the clinic cuz there was no civilians. In the clinic there's nurses who could testify against you. Could say whatever you want. Most of them fucking

hate us and the inmates more than anybody. They're the least compassionate people you've ever met in your life, I gotta be honest with ya. One time I first started, I'd never been put in a situation before, they had three pens in there. And what Drug Interdiction is for is, when the jail's running the way it's supposed to be and someone looks high, or you find drugs on their person, security's supposed to bring em down put em in a pen, they piss in a cup. But it became the ass-kicking room. They're giving out assignments and I'm new and they say, Brother you're off to Interdiction today, I say, why? Where? They say, We got someone in the pen and they can't be alone we need an officer. But don't open the door don't give em water don't do nothing. Sometimes they used it as an overflow for intake, but most of the time, if you're going in there you did something bad, you hit an officer or. And in this case I go in there, I'm not saying nothing, just making sure the guy's alive. He's just sitting on a bench still shackled, which you're not supposed to be but alright. I ask him, You alright? And he gives me fuck you eyes, don't say nothing. I sit down, think, This isn't so bad, I can do this eight hours. Suddenly I hear the keys rattling and the guy just starts fucking screaming. Cuz he knows what's coming. And it's this captain, I used to have great conversations with, he was this real smart guy. Atheist, used to be like, Yeah, had this Christopher Hitchens accent, he was Jamaican so a bit of the British flavor, really funny dude, when he'd talk. But as soon as he came in he looks up, tells me to lock

the door, I lock behind him. He looks at the box for the cameras where cameras supposed to be, they're not there but just to check, cuz they're not gonna tell you if they put them in, they're just gonna do it. So he checks, no cameras, they're removed. And he's beating this guy like a fucking pinata, and I'm immediately thinking, Yo this is my post. There are cameras outside the door. And if he came in without a scratch and comes out and he can't walk, there's gonna be cameras asked. You can't walk in a room and walk out like you did ten rounds with Tyson and claim the guy slipped. So I bend him over, get his face on the ground so they're only punching and kicking him in the body, so it won't show on his face, and they look at me like I'm doing some sadistic shit like what the fuck? They get him in the pen, he's a black dude, he says, You fuck with me nigga? And he had muscle on him. Don't fuck with me nigger. And he's fucking punching the motherfucking life out of this man, and the captain's standing there looking at me like, don't worry about it, and I go. Yo Cap this is my post, stop hitting him in the fucking face. Hit him in the body or something if you gotta but he can't walk outta here with a cracked skull. So they pull him out, the Cap left, and the inmate starts talking to me like, Yo officer thank you, that's what I like about you white boys you do your job. I knew I had it come it but they were doing extra. I'm like, well, good you knew you had it coming, first of all, spitting in an officer's face, she's a female, the Misses. You gotta call em Misses they like that even though they're officers. And like,

all these dudes are sick. They all got Hep C. A lot of them are HIV positive. It's just the lifestyle, they're rawdogging fucking whores and snorting things off toilets.

After that I had a lot of time to reflect. It was like, OK, I'm not a sadistic motherfucker, it's not that. But there are just times where. I mean I worked with guys who were straight up like, I like to torture motherfuckers. At night time what they do a lot of these places. Specially houses where they're crazy for real, or they're putting on a show cuz they're facing heavy charges, and they're trying to build the craziness cred for a plea, help their case. Hoping to get placed in a high security hospital which is preferable, they'll just pump you with fuckin thorazine and keep you high all day and you'll do your time that way. But I used to work with this guy, at midnight, see you're usually alone. There's this position ESO, like Enhanced Supervision and Observation, or something, I can't quite remember the acronym, it's usually a good gig unless the person's intent on harming themselves, but it's basically one-on-one watching a suicide risk all night, cuz as soon as they get a chance they'll hang or cut themselves or whatever. There was this dude, this Spanish dude, and they'll just scream all night and bang their heads on the wall and shit like that. And it agitates—not only is it just a difficult place to work but it agitates the other inmates who are trying to sleep, they're screaming Motherfucking I'm gonna kill you in the morning. Which isn't much of a threat if you're trying to die

that's just encouraging. We got these cameras anyway they're not night vision cameras you can see a picture but it's like looking at a negative. So what this dude used to do, you got your sprayer in your belt, and we'd carry straws and what we'd do is put the straw around the nozzle and as the guy's banging in there, you'd come up, lean against it like you're talking to him, but meanwhile you're sticking the straw through the door jam, the crack in the door, and you give him a fuckin dose of the hot sauce. And of course they freak the fuck out but then they quiet down. Because that shit's nasty, the stuff we use is a notch below bear spray, it's not the stuff you see people walking on a key chain with. Military grade. I was never with that stuff, the spraying when he did it, I'd be like, Yo that shit's gonna stink up the house, if the Dep walks, but I tell ya. This is a perfect example of how a Dep would, when they're walking, like, there's this one Dep who'd always say this: Everything all right as far as I know? Like, I don't wanna know. Don't ask don't tell. Yes sir, As far as you know everything's OK. It's just stuff like that. Gouging people's eyes and fish-hooking them and choking the shit out of them, stuff you can get away with under certain circumstances, maybe it's a pile of people, you're surrounding the guy with suits and the cameras can't see anything they're blocked by the turtle suits the cams just see your backs. So guys'd jam thumbs in the guys' eyes. You know what a fish hook is? You put your fingers at each side of a mouth and pull apart, give em a personal smile.

And I didn't mind the taunting so much if it were

me but if it were another officer. Especially if it's a new female officer. I don't care who you are, you're gonna feel fear. You're getting locked in a room with all these guys. Guys claim they don't feel fear I don't buy it. Courage isn't an absence of fear. You're scared but you still perform. Everyone feels it it's a human nervous system things. But when you're new you get hazed, they put you in the worst houses with uncontrollable people. So that's where you put newer bodies. From the Department's point of view, it's like, We're gonna find out if you're about this job, cuz if you ain't built for this job you're gonna quit. Say it's just like, the person's been there a month or so doing alright, they're not afraid to be in there. But the inmates know exactly what they can get away with, threaten you get around you. Grab your log book and rip it up. Used to be that was a legal document, I think now maybe they've changed it back, you're allowed to spray for it, cuz the Feds realized we still do everything by paper and pen, we're the only ones not computerized. Even cops writing tickets is done on a little computer, they look like card readers or big calculators or. But if I went to a Level B and it's some young Chinese American officer who goes, Yo man they kept coming up, Punking people basically, Making like you're gonna punch someone and then stopping. They jerk their body and bring their fist up just to see if you flinch. And they were making this guy's life miserable. And in those situations I'd become someone I didn't really like. I'd always tell them, You guys always do this when an officer's solo

on the floor, but now we're here it's an even fight.

When I was jumped by MS13 I was on OT and informed the whole jail was on lockdown due to a TSO (tactical search operation). There had been a spate of slashings between the Bloods & Trinitarios within a two day span. Under those circumstances the department will eventually lock everything down until they can get a handle on things. There's clearly a war going on. I was assigned on OT to a house that was half MS13 half Crips. They had a tense truce but didn't trust each other at all. When I took the post I did my security inspection & confiscated 4 or 5 'keys'. I was pretty mellow because all those guys sleep late etc. I was being cool. Like, if one inmate returned from court I'd be like "yo, I'll let you shower or whatever but first do me a favor. Go around and do a hot pot run" see, the hot water (basically a large electric coffee pot is in the dayroom & because everyone is locked in they don't have access. Every inmate is given like a 10oz. Green plastic mug upon entering facility (as well as uniform, towel, sheets etc) So this inmate was like sure. He was a Crip. Halfway through this chow (lunch arrives on post). The inmate who has the job to serve the food is also a Crip. I have to let him out. The MS dudes are getting antsy because they feel (with good reason) that they're gonna get shorted trays. Now most, but not all of the cell doors have like 7x6" slot that you can get the mug through, but not the trays. I'm going to have to individually serve each of these 28/30 dudes

myself. Meaning crack open their cell and give them the tray. You want to start from the back of the tier and work forward. Well the leader of the MS guys is the last cell on left, first one I open. So I got my key in one hand and am balancing a tray with my other hand. The leader pops out I hand him the tray and he refuses to lock back in. He walks to the front breaker gate and starts yelling at the 'A' officer, a young 90lb black female officer who was steady in the house to tell me to let them out. This shit ain't about them and all the while he's telling me 'Yo gringo MF'er, this lock in is over. You don't call the shots. We run this MF'er! &c.'" I'm like bro, nobody else is getting fed until you lock in. Foods getting cold" he starts back to his cell but is saying shit in Spanish to his boys like mira todos vamanos, we're all coming out. I follow his ass back to his cell and as he enters he applies a homemade key on the mechanism and says don't touch it. I pull that shit out and throw it on the floor. He lunges at me and I'm able to sort of push him back in. He grabs something and starts lunging again. I blast him with chemical agent and he retreats into his cell. Now remember: we are in the back of the house. All I hear is doors shaking. I'm like oh shit it's on. I see about five of his boys making it out of their cells. I'm just charging toward each and blasting with the spray. It was like playing wack a mole. One short but heavy dude starts coming at me and he's got something. I go to spray him and the can is empty. Now the leader had poured water

or milk in his eyes and come charging from behind me and just sort of football tackles me. The next thing I know there are like 4 of them stomping me.. it was like the Billy Batts scene in *GoodFellas*, they are just football kicking my head. I knew if I didn't get up I was gonna die. Every time I would half get up another would hit me from another direction. This went on for what feels like forever. I'm still trying to fight/grab hold/get up. Same result. The A officer is just screaming and crying her head off but she can't do anything. She has the main set of keys. If she opens the gate to help they can literally take over the whole house. I finally get to my feet. Covered in blood, and they all run back to their cells and lock themselves in! I'm like WTF! You fucking faggots...what I didn't know is that there was one officer who was passing in the hallway, big dude. He hears the her screaming and comes to the door & she let him in. I look over and see him and it was like Superman arrived. They wanted no part of this guy plus they are sprayed and winded from whooping my ass non stop.... Okay, there's more but I'm gonna fast forward to answer your question. I go to hospital get stitched up etc. I have to return to the facility now & write reports (yeah). The place is packed with brass. Warden, chiefs, all the big bosses. I'm walking with my escort officer. If you have to go out EMS, doesn't matter if it's an assault or just a medical emergency. An armed officer will accompany you as you are still in uniform, on duty and being taken to a hospital ER.

And I overhear the Chief saying to the tour commander “I don’t understand how this can happen during a lockdown” the ADW to his credit says “C’mon Chief, you know these cell doors don’t work”.. I kept walking to the tour commanders office to report. My escort is right behind me and he’s shaking his head in disbelief. I say “did you hear that shit?” He says yeah, that wasn’t the worst part though. I say what happened? He doesn’t want to tell me but relents and says the Chiefs reply to the ADW saying out loud that the doors don’t work was “well I hope that officer logged that in his security inspection.” That’s the shit we deal with.

Afterward, I was getting treated by PTS by this fucking former Israeli IDF psychologist. She was saying, you know, you need this, and I started doing EMDR, some kind of eye movement therapy thing? Basically your left brain and your right brain lose connectivity, and this is a technique where—I don’t wanna say you go into a trance or anything—but you close your eyes and use these vibrating paddles, and with your eyes close your laterally move your eyes to help connect, and it helps you go to the place you’re having the trouble. She said, the first thing you needa do is find a safe place, and I couldn’t think of one. Not at home, never, I never had a place where I felt in the water.

I’d taken a break from surfing. I mean I started as a preteen, and the only reason I started, to be honest with you—all of my siblings, I had a bunch and they were all good-looking, and when I was say

11 and she was 17, the beach was—you know what I mean? My hair got bleached from surfing. They called me Ponyboy, like after *The Outsiders*. My father used to take out a loan from the union and get us a bungalow at the beach for a week, you know? We did Rockaway for a minute, and then when Rockaway was in decline and getting dangerous, we started going to Breezy Point, the Irish Riviera they used to call it, very white Irish, firemen, they didn't even let Italians in back then. But it was a swim-at-your-own-risk situation. Could be a mile-long stretch with a single lifeguard. So my ma told my sister to keep an eye on me. And there were a lot of guys who wanted to court my sister, and they were surfers, so I ended up getting taken out in the waves. In my teens I started getting more into the music scene and sorta left it behind. Then a guy I knew, he had this catastrophic injury and severed his spine and he gave me his board, I'm in my twenties now, and I'd forgotten how much I missed it. It was a hobby for me then, a summertime thing, I'd bring the board on the subway. And it wasn't til my wife was at Japan Airways that I'd head down there to surf and see her, and there was this super fuckin cool old-school eighty year old clamhouse and I was just spendin so much time there and they asked me if I wanted to pick up a couple of shifts. Which led to my moving out here. That and judo, judo was my other therapy, my love love love. When I lived in Brooklyn it was a twenty minute subway and when

we moved to Rockaway it was an hour twenty, and if I'm training four five times a week, and paying a hefty annual membership, it just became untenable. How'd I get into judo? When I was a kid I was a total truant, we'd cut out and head to Broadway. The popular myth is that it was just a bunch of porno theaters but that's not true, you could get these great two-for-one ticket deals and we'd get beer, get high, whatever. It was a perverse wonderland.

And then sometimes in Brooklyn there used to be these dojos who would give you your first session free, so a group of us'd go get a class in karate or taekwondo or whatever free, never come back. Karate Kid had come out and there's this part in the movies where Mr Miyagi is like, You learn from book? Which was me, the kid in the movie practicing his kicks from the book. There was a place near where I lived, a Chinese bazaar called Treasure Island, and they sold Bruce Lee books and these weapons and I was totally hooked. And then in the 90s, there was this girl who gave me a real education, she graduated outta Purchase with all the guys who started *The Shooting Gallery* like Edie Falco and Nick Gomez. Which, I knew all those guys.

I have to preface by saying, all those shows, *The Sopranos*, *The Wire* was my favorite, I never—to be honest with you—I don't think there's anything since when I was a kid, Happy Days, where I waited for the next week. I always binged when I was

recovering from an injury on the job. But while I was an actor I'd never seen *The Sopranos*. I used to bartend Sunday nights in Brooklyn and when that show was on, I think it started at eight or nine but literally $\frac{3}{4}$ of the people would get up to catch the show, it was such a phenomenon and I'd never seen it. I went to this audition, there was a character in the first few seasons, there was this side character who I auditioned for, a friend of Chris's but I didn't know what the *Sopranos* was, but I was throwing in extra dialogue, improving, doing the Brooklyn thing. They weren't happy with that. But just from being on the theater scene I knew Edie Falco, we did an episode of L&O together. Gandolfini's son was in my judo club, and Paulie Walnuts lived down the street. But it wasn't til I was in Corrections where I'd get injured, I'd be on the bench two weeks and we'd have Amazon Prime or whatever, maybe Netflix and I'd binge it. You can barely walk, you're waiting for a knee to heal.

I was dating this Nuyorican girl, she was a filmmaker, she gave me a helluva education on film, she'd gone to a college in Arizona and been the Arizona kickboxing champion, and I can remember really clearly we were living in Park Slope, I can remember it clearly, railroad apartment, we had a chinup bar with a punching bag and I'm watching *The Simpsons* one day smoking a cigarette and she is like, pounding the shit outta this bag, and I'm thinkin, if shit ever goes south with this girl she's gonna kick my ass. I was

just bartending and acting so I'm getting a bit of a belly. I was smoking cigarettes all the time working my mid-twenties and one time I couldn't breathe and I said, that's it, and I threw the package in the trash quit cold turkey. And I'd been reading about factory farming, and I go, Yo, that ain't right, I gotta change something. And I guess I was on what you'd call a spiritual journey, it wasn't about dogma it about the way martial arts and surfing made me feel, realizing there's a dimension beyond our comprehension and trying to follow the way of that... that current. And I decided eating meat was immoral. That got me through a lot of years. I don't think I drank five years straight. Didn't eat meat twenty years, at least pork, red meat, twenty years. Fish... Going to Japan, seeing what I put my inlaws through, my poor mother-in-law trying to feed me on this island. I said, No no I'm gonna eat what you give me. And then my daughter when she was born, she was real thin, tall but thin, and her pediatrician, Greek woman, went, look I know how you feel about it but she's gotta get vitamins. She won't take medicine, she won't take pills, so you gotta try to introduce some animal proteins. We don't want her getting anemic. So of course I went and got a London broil that day, she had a couple pieces, I ate the rest of it, went Oh my god what've I been missing.

Anyways, martial arts. I first started with Japanese jiu jitsu and earned a black belt in that and then the guy moved to the Carolinas, he wanted me to take

over the dojo, he'd collect the money and I'd do all the work, and I said nah, so I found a new spot in Manhattan. And it really saved me, the only thing that stopped me getting indicted on charges while I was at the DOC, I mean, when push comes to shove you're gonna go back to what you know, and judo was a very hands-on, you know, very akin to wrestling, so other guys they get into a fight with inmates, they're punching the fuckin shit outta guys breakin eye sockets on camera, it's really hard to defend in court, they'll say it's excessive force. But with judo you'd hold em down. I mean we'd do a thing, we'd instinctively know where the cameras were and we'd put our bodies in front of it to protect the other officer.

You never want to leave a session looking back at the ocean. I wanna limp outta the water. I wanna be done done. It became totally impossible to surf while in the DOC. But then after de Blasio allowed cashless bail the jails just emptied out. C-95 has a capacity of like 2300 inmates and that's the biggest jail. The rest are smaller. Some by a lot some by a little. And it got down to 900 inmates. That was the best summer of my life. There was a crew of four or five officers I taught to surf and we used to be like, Yo go home get your gear, some of them were so stoked their shit was already in the car and we'd head straight to the beach, some of them would bring beers or breakfast, cuz this was after a morning shift, and you could sleep for three or four hours and still get some sleep. Any other year, I had to wait til vacation to surf, which I

took in December cuz my that's when my daughter and brother and wife's birthdays are, and we'd go somewhere warm, go down to Coco Beach or Puerto Rico. Rest of the year, you have time off? First day you're so exhausted you sleep all day, second day you spend washing your uniform and equipment.

I remember I was in Puerto Rico one time, Rincon, years ago, 2001, at a lucky time, you could see the fish trails at night, the algae was bioluminescent would be like lasers lighting up. It was right after 9/11, a month there, I didn't wanna go but the girl I was going with, we'd planned it, it was unrefundable. There'd just been a hurricane, we were staying at someone's bungalow, real surfer's shack type thing, and you had to walk a mile to the only pay phone that worked, all the power had been knocked out. My mother was still alive and I was calling home, I was still in shock by the towers coming down. I remember every single Puerto Rican house flying an American flag in solidarity. Because they all know people in the city.

Few years back I started running a surf camp out at the Rockaways. Rockapulco I call it. It was always the surfing ladies of the Rockaways. Periodic roar of a plane overhead, on its way to or from JFK Airport. The men tended to be like, Yo just show me what to do. When I first started with a guy, that's how he started—throw a board on the sand, paddle paddle, pop up, and say Aight I got it, let's go in the water. Lot of arrogance. The women didn't have the ego. Teach em water safety. Teach em eggbeaters. Peeling peaks. Closest to the peak has priority.

I remember I was at Christmas party a year after the incident, some of the guys still awaiting trial, and one of the guys told an officer at the trial, you tell Kern we're gonna get him. Luckily all those guys were facing life, they did real horrible things, kinda guys decapitate people, cut up bodies. One guy was facing just an arson wrap, he was trying to burn a body or something, and he was looking at six years for assaulting me. But ICE really wanted him, he's wanted down in Florida, they're gonna extradite him. And he said if they take him down to El Salvador they're gonna kill him. So it's your decision, this DA said, I said, Let em have him. They're all out on Long Island these days. If you go to a West Hampton catering hall, half those busboys are MS13, if they took their shirts off you'd see a lotta tattoos.

I dream of Rikers 5 out of 7 nights. Like I'm still there. As fucked up as it was. I remember the peace of being on the overnight and just reading books at 3am. But what I really miss, and it's fucked up. Is the insanity of people screaming and bashing their heads into the wall for hours at a time. It's not an easy thing to explain. It was one of the few things that matched the screaming (figuratively) child still haunting and damning my own thoughts. There's no Schadenfrueda attached to the inmates. It was a kinship of being tortured-slash-haunted mentally.

What does Rikers do to a man's soul? It destroys it. When I first got there, it was clear to me immediately, the inmate culture was a constant even among the staff. I think I kept myself from an almost permanent

savagery. It's not cosplay though, and it's not a pawn shop. Some things you just ain't getting back.

What does the job do to a man's soul? It destroys it. Officer Boyd was my instructor back at Academy, guy looked like a linebacker. Guy committed suicide by cop not too long ago. Wife called in saying he had a psychiatric breakdown. Cops responded and he charged them with a knife, just to make sure they gunned him down and he didn't hurt anyone. I mean he was a Pat Tillman type, like there's a guy you look up to.

Look at veterans' suicides. Last time I checked, it's about seven or eight a day in the US. Lot of stuff underreported, guys who drive into telephone poles. Guys liked to call themselves paramilitary, but there's no discipline, they just stand in a line for role call and collect checks. They ain't tough. Most of them are in the job for the benefits, to get outta the projects. As long as you don't have a violent crime, a felony on your record, you could have a long rap sheet they'll let you serve. But for a lot of African-Americans it must have felt a bit like that, a bit like in the Army. You know, back in Alabama they were calling me "nigger" to my face, and now I'm out in Nam burning down villages a million miles away, what the fuck am I doing? I mean guys from the community would get to them, going, You're working for the man, you're an overseer on a plantation. Their only rhetort was: Yeah I just bought a Land Rover, what about you? You still pickin through the garbage can? My kid goes to private school, you don't even take care of your

kid! Wasn't especially productive. But guys would feel better if it was Larry Summers or Harvey Weinstein they were holding down and spraying. You gotta understand this is intergenerational.

And I miss it. Lotta people thrive in chaos, lotta inmates thrive in chaos, lotta COs, especially the black women, they look to just scream, you know, over-dramatic screaming. I dunno, things slow down for me. There's a comfortable place there. Once I got over the initial, "Oh, what am I gonna do," cuz the way the department treats you, Everything you do is wrong, so once I got over the, "What did I do wrong here," I liked it. I didn't like, if it was an inmate, that I had a good relationship with... I knew guys that liked to torture people with mental illness, I hated that. These fucking guys, and they were all, well not all, but mostly the same. When you're dealing with mental illness people you're never alone, there's always at least one person on suicide watch. Sometimes you'll have six guys with you, there's almost a pissing contest who can be the biggest and the baddest, who can come up with the most creative ways to shut people. But the guys I worked with, none of them would have acted that way alone in a ganghouse, they'd lose that swagger in a minute. And the thing I always prided myself on, I always treated guys the same way, the guys who were there for 3 days I'd treat the same as the most violent. Lotta these guys would stay locked in cuz they were so violent, like Lucifer. I always fed him. They'd say, Don't do that! He's gonna... And I'd go, Bro he's gotta eat. He's a human being. You gotta

at least offer it to him. Sometimes he wouldn't even let you get near him, he'd be shouting at you through the cell bars, he'd start splashin n stuff, that's when they throw stuff at you, cum or feces or. I'd threaten em, it's gonna turn into Ramadan for you, gonna turn into a diet. But I always fed em. And I always did my job.